Nine Lives

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34639813.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death, Underage, Rape/Non-Con

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), She-Ra, Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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Nine Lives

by MerthurArts

Summary

What comes after the agony of your life falling apart in front of your very eyes? Is it a world of fire and sickness if you're deemed bad enough, like Shadow Weaver always told them? And if it was, would she be sent there? She tried to think back on her life in those few seconds she had left. Was there anything she had done to deserve an afterlife of torture? She hadn't killed anyone or cheated or anything like that. She hadn't asked for the cards she'd been dealt in life, so really it wasn't her fault for fighting her former best friend. So, no. Catra did not believe she belonged in Hell. But that didn't necessarily mean she'd end up in Heaven with streets of gold and flower petals all around her.

Taking a final glance down, Catra saw she was almost on the ground. Her time had come, she was about to die.

Or: in which Catra has nine lives and each time she dies she relives one of the memories she forced herself to forget. Based off Stevenson's post.

Notes

Welcome to my newest fanfic! I absolutely fell in love with Catra when I watched She-ra. I liked the idea of delving into her past, so I provide you with this. Please comment below what you think. Thank you guys.

Princess Prom Meltdown

The only thing Catra could think of as She-ra clung to her arm, was of petty revenge. Adora chose to leave her. She chose the princess' side over the ones who raised her. She gave up everything she'd ever wanted, everything she worked so hard for within a day. And for what? Dress up games and dumb sparkly girls? It was hardly a fair trade. How could she possibly be happy? How could she even live with herself?

Catra wanted to make her pay. She wanted her to hurt the way she hurt, lose a friend just as she had. She wanted Adora to understand the feeling that nothing was ever going to be right again. In that instant she knew what she wanted to- scratch that, knew what she had to do.

So just after her blonde nemesis promised to help her, Catra smirked. "Oh Adora, I don't want you to." She took one glance at the girl's shocked face. Then she let go.

It was only when the cold air hit the fingertips of the hand Adora had been holding, had she realized her fatal mistake. There was nothing to catch her below, except the unforgiving ground thousands of feet below.

"Catra!" The scream barely made it to her ears as the wind whipped through her mess of hair. Her heterochromia eyes were squeezed shut, closing off the wind that tried to force its way into her very soul.

She had given a lot of thought to dying in the past, everyone in the Fright Zone had. You couldn't grow up in a time of war without knowing that it was a very real possibility. But one thing she hadn't wondered about was actual death. Adora always told her the two of them would probably go out in a burst of flames, so she'd sort of imagined it being painful. Crashing, to the ground would break her bones, probably her neck. It seemed a bit more

painful, but that wasn't what scared her. What scared her was the question, "What comes next?"

What comes after the agony of your life falling apart in front of your very eyes? Is it a world of fire and sickness if you're deemed bad enough, like Shadow Weaver always told them? And if it was, would she be sent there? She tried to think back on her life in those few seconds she had left. Was there anything she had done to deserve an afterlife of torture? She hadn't killed anyone or cheated or anything like that. She hadn't asked for the cards she'd been dealt in life, so really it wasn't her fault for fighting her former best friend. So, no. Catra did not believe she belonged in Hell. But that didn't necessarily mean she'd end up in Heaven with streets of gold and flower petals all around her.

So, then what? Would there be nothing; only an unending darkness for the rest of time? Would she even be conscious and remember her past life? Or would she be stuck in an endless loop reliving her worst memories, like one of those scary movies she'd watched as a kid?

Taking a final glance down, Catra saw she was almost on the ground. Her time had come, she was about to die. She didn't scream even as she felt all her bones breaking. She lay sprawled out awkwardly, her limbs going in all the wrong directions. For a moment she felt excruciating pain, a suffering she'd never felt before, not even with all the abuse she had withstood in the Fright Zone. And then, just like that, it was over, and she felt nothing but an overwhelming sense of peace. She was dead, at only 19 years old.

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Catra looked up to the masked woman in terror. Her fur was on edge, and she could feel herself shaking. She knew she shouldn't have risked a nap. But she was so tired, and the sun had felt so warm. She had thought if she just closed her eyes for ten seconds, she would be fine. But now she stood here in this

creepy old dude's lair, having been literally dragged in only moments before. Clearly she had been very wrong.

"What is the reason for your untimely disturbance this time Shadow Weaver?" The robotic looking man glared at her from his throne. She felt as if his red eyes could see right through her.

"I apologize Lord Hordak, but this- "The masked lady threw Catra forward so the girl landed at her feet. "This was just lying by the entrance. I assumed it was a spy my lord, so I wanted you to see for yourself."

The man stood from the chair, his bones seeming to rattle as he did so. He walked down from the platform and grabbed the young girl by the scruff of her neck.

"HEY!" She hissed, unleashing her claws. Hordak didn't draw back at the sight of her hands. Instead, he grabbed them, to examine them closer.

"This is no spy! It's a child! You see this as a threat to me, the almighty one?" He tossed her back to the ground so he could unleash his full amount of fury onto the woman.

She backed farther away, protecting herself and never once caring about the young girl huddled on the floor. "Of course not my lord, I just thought it would be an opportunity to get back at the Rebellion. If we hold their spy hostage, we can barter for another kingdom.

"THIS is not a spy, Shadow Weaver!" He hissed, pointing at the mess of hair in his sanctum. "The only useful thing you could do with it is recruiting it!"

Shadow Weaver gasped. "Surely you don't want me to raise that thing! Its mangey!"

Hordak grabbed her by the neck, picking the woman up off the floor. "I don't care what you do with it! Send it to Beast Island,

keep it, I don't know! Just get it out of my sight! Now!" With that he threw her backwards and he retreated to his throne.

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Catra was being dragged to her doom when she first set eyes on the blonde girl. She jumped right out in front of Shadow Weaver, her hands on her hips. "Where you taking her?" She demanded.

The woman stopped in her tracks, her grip never letting up. "Adora, this is no concern of yours. Now go back to your room."

"No." The girl demanded. "Who she?"

"Just a wretch I captured, but as I said Adora, it is no concern of yours. Now, I remember giving you a command to go back to your quarters cadet."

Catra looked into the little girl's eyes. They were full of life, nothing like the people she'd come across since she'd escaped the orphanage. She could tell she was a strong and loyal person, one who she wished she had as a friend.

And maybe in that instant, God heard her prayer. All her silent pleas for a family were about to come true. Adora took Catra's unoccupied hand and tried to pull her forward. "Kitty come with me!"

"Adora, you don't want this flea-ridden thing. Trust me, she'll be much better off at Beast Island."

The blonde girl's eyes grew three times the size. "With the monsters?" When Shadow Weaver nodded, Adora did the complete opposite of what Catra expected. She let go of her and sat down on the cold floor, her gaze rivaling the older woman's.

"What are you doing?" Shadow Weaver sighed, pressing a hand to her temple in utter exhaustion. Catra stared between the two, her eyes never wavering from the staring contest that was happening before her.

"I won't do more fighting 'less you let kitty stay!" Adora demanded.

After a long few minutes of trying to talk sense into her pupil, the masked woman gave up. "Very well, she can stay."

"Yay!" Adora tackled her new best friend in a tight hug. Catra tried backing away to no avail.

"BUT you are responsible for her Adora and you alone."

The girl nodded eagerly, before dragging Catra back to her dorm room. "I will!" She called over her shoulder.

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Catra sat on one of the empty beds, while Adora searched under her own for something apparently important. The first thing she noticed about the room was how tidy it was. It looked nothing like she imagined a kid's room. There were no toys or marking on the wall. The blankets were straight as if no one had slept in here in ages. If Adora hadn't told her otherwise, she would have assumed it was unused.

She didn't like the tidiness of this place. It made her feel trapped and all she wanted to do was run away. But she would have to wait until night when everyone was asleep.

"AHA!" The sudden noise brought the girl back to reality. Adora jumped onto the bed beside her, now holding a half empty jar of applesauce. "I stole it from the guards!" She loudly whispered holding a finger over her mouth.

Catra chuckled at this, the first laugh she had in a long time. When the blonde opened the bottle and handed her a spoonful, she gladly took it. Her mouth burst at the taste of sweet food. She let out a quiet hum of satisfaction. "This is reawwy good! Thanks 'Dora."

Adora cocked her head, staring at her new friend. "What's your name?"

Catra took another glorious spoonful of the tart sauce. "My name?"

"You know, what they call you." She probed.

She shrugged. "Sometimes they call me furball or mange-pelt." She supplied hopefully.

"You don't have a name!?" The other girl gasped, her hands flying up to rest on the cat-girl's shoulders. "Well, I'll fix that!" She stared into space, her fingers moving to rest under her chin as she contemplated names. "Cattt-" She tried out.

"You can't call me Cat, that's weird. It's like calling you 'person'."

"Hmmmm, you right. My name has a 'ra' at the end. Maybe I could do that with you? How about CatRa? Like AdoRA? That way evyone will know we're friends?" She suggested.

"Catra," She tried out, nodding in satisfaction. "I'm Catra!"

Adora smiled broadly. "Catraaa-" She glanced around the room, her eyes finally locking on the now almost empty jar. "Applesauce!"

"Catra Applesauce?" She raised an inquisitive eyebrow. Her new friend nodded eagerly.

"Applesauce can be your middle name. 'Cause we both like applesauce!" She declared. "And your last name can be…"

Just then Catra took a heaping spoonful. She took so much some of it spilled in her lap. "Mrroww!" She leaped backwards, trying desperately to free herself of the stickiness.

Adora laughed. "Catra Applesauce MeowMeow!" She clapped her hands, proud of her clever ideas.

Catra tackled Adora, causing the jar to fall off the bed, the treat spilling everywhere. "That's a bad name! There's too many words!"

Adora giggled, rolling her friend onto her back, the two wrestling for power over one another. "It's a cute name!"

"Mrrrowww! If my name is Catra Applesauce MeowMeow, then yours is Adora Glitter Speak!"

Adora pushed her off the bed in a swift motion. "Catra, that's even worse!"

"CAaaTtttRaaaa!" *A distorted voice called out from the darkness. She had been torn from her memories and thrown back into the void. She looked around for Adora, but there was no one there. No one except for her and the voice. "CAAAATRAAAAA!"*

She tried to walk forward but found herself unable to move. It was if a pair of invisible chains were holding her against her will. "Who are you?" She called out.

"CATRAAAAA!" *The voice was a mere whisper and yet at the same time it reverberated around her head, playing tricks on her ears. "YOU'VE FORGOTTEN CATRA!"*

"What? What have I forgotten! Get out here and face me, you coward!" She suddenly found herself spinning in circles, unable to stop herself. Distant memories flashed all around her, but as soon as they disappeared, they were lost from her memory.

"REMEMMMBERRRRR! REMEMBER!"

"Remember what!?" She cried out, still helplessly spinning.

"REEEMEEEMMMBERRRRRRRR!"

Without any further warning she was thrown backwards. Her back hit something so hard, the breath was knocked out of her lungs. An intense pain, the same one she felt earlier returned, only this time not quite as bad. A blinding light shone right at her, forcing her to shut her eyes.

When the light dissipated, she was finally able to open them. "Ughhh." She cried out in agony. She found herself staring up at a familiar face; Scorpia. "Wha- What happened?"

Scorpia knelt down beside her. "Wildcat! I thought you were dead! Oh my goodness, I am so SO happy you're alive!"

Catra stared at her. Was she dead? She should have been. Nobody could survive a fall like that. And what she had witnessed, those were memories she had tried her best to lock away as far as possible. So surely, if she were conscious, she would have forced herself to stop thinking about it. Unless…

Had Catra actually died when she landed? But if she had, how was she here now?

Memories arose from her biology class back in the Hoard. They had learned that cats had 9 lives. Was it the same for her? And if so, that would mean she just lost her first one, all thanks to She-ra.

She growled, pushing Scorpia out of her way as she pushed herself to her feet. "Don't be stupid, I didn't die. Obviously, I'm still alive."

"Hey there Wildcat," Scorpia went to help her up, "maybe you should take it easy. That was quite the fall. You're lucky Kyle was able to rescue you in-"

"I'm FINE Scorpia, so quit treating me like a child!" She pushed her pincer away, stumbling as she rose. "Go up Kyle!" She screamed at the boy. "I want Adora to know I'm still here and I'm ready to take her down!"

Promise to never leave me?

Chapter Notes

Hey guys, just wanted to let you know that there will be some dark scene's in this story as it's Catra centric and she has some dark thoughts. As well as this, there is light gore in this chapter as this is the time Catra dies in the episode Promise. Once again, thank you all for reading, and please let me know what you think below.

Here she was once again, finding herself clinging onto Adora's hands. This time, however, she did not want to let go. She did not want to die again, lose her friend once more. If she came back to life she knew nothing would change, she'd still be in the Horde, still trying to fit in as a full-fledged member, she'd still be Hordak's warrior.

But if she stayed? If she lived, perhaps she could reunite with her former best friend. She imagined herself leaving the Horde, once and for all. She wouldn't join the Rebellion, hell no. She would run away with Adora. They would go to the farthest reaches of Etheria where nobody could find them. They would be happy.

Catra looked into the girl's eyes. 'Promise to never leave me?' Her silent plea begged, trying to reach her friend's heart.

But as she looked up at her, she caught a glance of that damned sword, the one that tore them apart in the first place. The gold seemed to wink back at her knowingly. Her heart shattered into a million pieces once more as she started to let herself slip away.

Adora found her destiny. She made new friends now, she didn't need Catra anymore. And even if she gave up her life at the Horde, she knew that the blonde wouldn't leave the Rebellion for her.

In the months since Adora left her, Catra hadn't allowed herself to think about anything but vengeance. What kind of friend would leave somebody behind? She hated her, despised her for it. Here she was ranting about being such a good person when the reality was that she broke the one she left behind.

But for the first time, Catra felt nothing except for the pain she'd been pushing down. What was the point of fighting She-ra? It wasn't like she was going to come back any time soon. So, for the second time, she let her fingers slip.

"Catra!" The voice fell on deaf ears. She didn't care anymore. If the spider killed her, she would come back to life and she wouldn't have to see her now enemy staring back at her.

Catra took one more glance at the girl before shutting her eyes and letting herself be carried away. She was dragged back into the darkness of the monster's lair. Around her hundreds of giant spiders watched her with their wicked eyes gleaming. She braced herself as their chelicerae bit down on her much smaller body.

"Aagghhhh!" She screamed, her world growing blurry as the venom worked its way into her.

This death was much worse than her first, she decided hazily. At princess prom, she had died almost as soon as she hit the ship. She hadn't had much time to focus on the pain before she was resurrected.

This time she could feel her limbs ripping slowly from her body. 'Was it worth it Adoraaa?' she wondered idly. 'Was you stupid fantasy worth letting me die nine different deaths?'

Visions started to dance about her memory, the real world slowly slipping away from her as her second life was taken. She saw herself being dropped off at the orphanage by the stranger that found her in a cardboard box on the shoulder of a road. She saw herself planning her escape, packing up the few things she

had collected in her four years of life. She saw her first winter outside, where she'd almost died from hypothermia. She hadn't, thanks to some miracle or another. But now she wondered if it was even a miracle at all.

The last thing she saw was the person she wanted to see the least; Adora, it was always Adora. No matter how hard she tried to erase her from her past, she was always there, bringing agony to the girl's already broken heart and soul.

"A- Adoraaa…"

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"Adora! Adora!"

"Mmmm, Catra, go back to sleep."

The little girl lashed her tail. She pulled the blankets off of her friend and jumped into the bed with her. "I can't! The night is calling me!"

Adora flipped herself over, pulling the blankets back up. "And the night's calling me to go back to sleep." She mumbled.

Catra leaned over her body, her yellow and green eyes glowing in the dark. Her claws drummed quietly on the off-white sheets. "Please Adora?" Then, more quietly, she continued, "I had that dream again."

Adora sat up, grabbing her friend's hand. "The one about Shadow Weaver sending you to Beast Island?"

Catra bowed her head and nodded solemnly. "Mmhmm."

Adora draped her arms around her shoulders. "I won't ever let that happen to you." She vowed.

"But what if there's nothing you can do to stop her?"

“You’re my best friend in the entire world Catra. I would never let you go. And if she did send you to Beast Island, she would have to send me too!”

Catra gave her a weak smile. “You would give up everything you trained for to come with me?”

“Of course!” Adora exclaimed, staring into her eyes. “I love you Catra. No war is worth giving up my bestest friend ever.”

Catra purred, hugging Adora back. Her hair smelled like iron and dust, but to her there was no better scent in the world. “I bet we’d be able to kick those monster’s asses.” She whispered into the girl’s ear.

Adora gasped, pulling out of the hug to cover her innocent ears. “Catra Applesauce MeowMeow, that’s a forbidden word!” She squealed.

Catra winked playfully. “Says Shadow Weaver! What’s it matter what kind of rules we break if we’re going to be exiled anyway?”

Adora crossed her arms, letting out a huff of slight annoyance. “We’re not kicked out yet!”

Catra closed her eyes and laughed. Adora smiled brightly, all annoyance instantly forgotten. She started to laugh with her.

“Hey, since we’re both wide awake now, how about we go explore a little?”

The girl’s smile broadened as she leapt to her feet, pulling Adora with her. “You know me so well!”

The girls tiptoed out of their bunker and into the silent halls. Everybody was either sleeping or out in battle right now, so they had the entire place basically to themselves.

“Hey,” Adora suggested, “how about we go to the roof?”

"Okay, let's go!" They ran through the corridors until they came to the red ladder. Catra nimbly jumped up, using her claws to pull herself through the trap door. Adora followed, just as quickly from all her time hanging out with her friend.

"Race you to the platform!" Adora yelled, starting to run even before she got all her words out.

"Hey! No fair!" Catra pounced on her, bringing them both to the ground. They wrestled for a little until she finally came out on top. Staying on all fours, she bounded forwards. She dug her claws into the post and climbed up.

Adora took out her grappling hook, throwing it upwards so that it caught on the platform. She made it to the top just a second later. She fell onto the wood panting.

Catra threw her fists into the air. Her mess of hair blew in every direction, making her look even more like her namesake. "Aha, Victory!" She purred, pleased with herself.

"I would have bet you if you didn't cheat." Adora stated, moving to lay on her back.

Catra sat down beside her. "Just admit it Adora, you can't keep up with my awesome cat-like abilities."

"That's not true, its just that-" She was cut off by her friend's claws tickling her. "Catra- Catra stop!" She laughed, trying to squirm away.

"Not until you admit that I'm faster than you!" She quipped, her claws making their way to Adora's neck.

Hardly able to contain herself any longer, Adora finally gave in. "Okay, okay! You're the best!"

Catra smirked, still not stopping her attack. “What was that? I couldn’t hear you?”

“I said you’re faster than me!” Adora growled, pushing Catra off of her and switching their positions. Catra inhaled at the sudden change. “Now, admit I’m stronger than you!” She grinned playfully.

Catra could have done more to get out of her situation, but to be honest she didn’t want to. She knew she was stronger than Adora in every aspect other than following instruction. But she was so proud of herself. Catra could at least let her have that. “Okay. You’re stronger than me.”

Adora’s eyes widened at how quick her friend was to admit that. She quickly climbed off of her and lay back on the planks. Catra did the same.

There was a comfortable silence between them. The only thing they could hear was the hum of the machines working below and one another’s breath. Then Catra spoke, breaking the fragile quiet. “Adora?”

“Yeah?” She turned her head to see her friend staring up at the starless sky.

“Promise to never leave me?” Her voice was so quiet that the girl almost didn’t hear her.

Blue eyes stared into the heterochromia pair, understanding every unspoken emotion there. “I will never leave you Catra, as long as I’m alive.”

Satisfied with the answer she’d been given, she turned her head back to the night. After another minute, she spoke once more. “Adora?”

“Yeah?”

“I love you too.”

"CAaaTraaaa."

Damn it, she cursed as she was forced away from the memory as quickly as she'd been taken into it. Once more dark emptiness enveloped her, swallowing her whole. That memory had been extra painful as it had been the promise she'd held onto ever since she was a kid. Adora said she'd never leave. She said they'd do everything together, but obviously a promise meant nothing to her. She had left Catra alone. She'd left her to die. And she hated her for it.

"CAATRAAAA! IT'S TIME TO WAKE UP!"

She hissed at the voice. "Like I have any choice in the matter. You drag me here and there and through every bad thing that has ever happened to me and you tell me to wake up!? What the fuck is wrong with you?"

"YOU NEED TO REMEMBER!"

"What do I need to remember, just tell me already or leave me the hell alone!"

"REMEMBER THE PROMISSSE!"

The promise? The one that Adora broke? Is that what the voice wanted, her to extract her revenge? Huh, well she could do that

*Catra could feel her body convulse as she slowly started to wake up. Her head throbbed and eve*rything hurt. She could already tell that the beasts had torn her ligaments. She moaned as she forced herself up.

A quick look around revealed that she was alone once more. The spiders must have given up, thinking that she was dead. "I'm

still alive, dimwits.” She muttered under her breathe. She had won that battle, even if it was the hard way.

But there was no Adora either. She hadn’t come to find her. She had also left her for dead. Catra let out a feral growl and she unsteadily got to her feet, her limbs hanging limp by her sides.

Adora didn’t care about her, and she certainly didn’t love her. That was fine though, Catra didn’t either. In fact she was about to prove a lesson to the girl. She would show her just how strong she really was. She would leave her for dead, just as Adora had left her.

A Reunion to Remember

Chapter Notes

I'm not saying I'd have kicked the Rebellion's ass to stay with Catra... But I'm not denying it either.

If you guys were wondering, their ages in the chapters so far are listed below.

Chapter 1- 5 years old

Chapter 2- 10 years old

Chapter 3- 12 years old

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra could hear her own steps as she made her way down the corridor. Every soldier she passed ducked her head as they saw her, but she hardly paid any attention to them. Her mind was too plagued by thoughts of what Hordak could possibly want. Ever since Entrapta- ever since *that* fiasco happened, he hardly asked to speak with her anymore.

So why now? Her ears twitched at a sound. She idly wondered if it could be Shadow Weaver, lurking somewhere in the shadows. But she knew it wasn't. She would have been long gone by now.

Catra wanted to scream at her own stupidity. She should have known Shadow Weaver would betray her, just as she'd always done. But after all those years of Adora being the "chosen one", and Adora getting all the attention, and Adora this and that, she just wanted to believe she deserved the same treatment. But

why would it be any different, even with her perfect prodigy gone? Why would all those years of torment suddenly be forgotten? Why would Catra ever have *anything* in her life go right, even just this once?

The truth was that she was still that weak little kitten left in a box, forgotten, abandon, helpless, and alone. Perhaps Shadow Weaver had been right. Maybe Catra really was just a misfit who only belonged so long as precious princess Adora wanted her there. Maybe without her friend she was nothing.

Drawing a shaky breath, she saw that she arrived at her leader's sanctum. Her claws scraped against the metal door. "Enter." Came a deep-throated voice from inside.

She bowed her head as she made her way into the room. "You wanted to see me Hordak?"

He didn't acknowledge how her voice shook. He just stared, those evil red eyes forever seeing through her very soul. "Yes, force captain." His voice was low, guttural. He was faking pleasantries when the reality was that he only wanted her for something. Probably some new stupid mission to find more First Ones Tech. "I wished to 'touch base,' as you said."

Her eyes widened in surprise. She hadn't been expecting this. If this was some scheme of his- but another voice whispered in her ear. What if it wasn't a ploy at something? What if he actually was starting to take her seriously?

She took a quick glance around before finally speaking. “Everything is going according to plan.” She lied, the words came out so easily now, she didn’t even think twice about lying. Perhaps she should have.

Hordak stared at her for a long moment. Catra could feel sweat drip down her face and her legs grow shaky. Why wasn’t he saying anything? He couldn’t possibly know anything was up, not when he refused to leave this room.

“Does this mean Shadow Weaver has been sent to Beast Island as I commanded?” It wasn’t a question. They both knew that.

Catra squinted at him. What was he getting at? “Yes, I sent her yesterday,” she informed him, “believe me, we are never going to see her again-“

And then the worst-case scenario happened. Something fluttered overhead, before letting out a sharp squeak. “I lost Shadow Weaver!”

Catra’s world shattered at her feet with those words- her words. The words she’d just told Scorpia in confidence not long ago. Hordak knew. He knew that she went against his orders, defied him, and worst of all he knew that she failed.

She could feel some part of her telling her to turn on her heels and run as far as she could. But Hordak's eyes kept her rooted in place. "Shadow Weaver escaped! I have to find her before Hordak learns the truth!"

She couldn't move, couldn't speak. She told Scorpia one of her deepest secrets and this is how she was repaid for it! She knew keeping friends too close was a setup for disaster and yet she fell into the trap anyway.

She fell onto the floor, ready to flee if necessary. She distantly heard his words over the pounding of her heartbeat. "You lied to me!"

He surged forward, pulling a lever on his way. The oxygen was stripped from her lungs and suddenly she could hardly tell what was happening. The next thing she remembered before loosing her third life was her futile struggle against Hordak as he strangled her.

For a brief moment her lungs felt like they were going to collapse from lack of air. Her throat ached from her being held up by her throat for an extended period of time. Then she felt a bone snap in her neck and her world went completely black once more.

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The sound of laughing made its way into her foggy head. She looked up from the floor to find Rogelio standing over her, holding a metal pole to her throat. Lonnie was the one chuckling about the whole thing, making fun of the girl.

"Well well, looks like the mighty wittle kitty cat lost this one!"

Catra hissed at her before wiggling herself out from under the staff. She pounced on Lonnie, pushing her to the ground. The other girl grunted as her head hit hard. "Say that again, I fucking dare you!"

Rogelio muttered something unintelligible. She whipped her head around to face him. "You wanna be next?"

He held up his hands in surrender, backing off. "That's what I thought!"

"Catra!" A voice called from the doorway of the training room. "Get off of Lonnie!"

Adora. Catra obeyed because, well it was Adora, and there wasn't anything she wouldn't do for her. She licked her hand, starting to wash her hair.

Lonnie rolled her eyes. "Yeah, go run. Your owner is calling."

Catra went stock still at her words. She was just about to start screaming when Adora once again interrupted her.

"I am <u>not</u> her owner!" Her tone was icy. Everyone in the room stopped what they were doing as the blonde stormed over to her friend. Lonnie looked like she was about to puke. Catra was very disappointed when she didn't. Still the show that was about to come was something to be admired.

At that moment, even if Adora was at least a head shorter, she towered over Lonnie. "In fact, Catra is the one who takes care of me here! And if anyone threatens her, I <u>will</u> hunt them down. So, if you're going to tease anybody about following someone around like a pet, choose me. But, let it be known, I will fight back!"

Lonnie had no time to react before somebody started clapping in the background. They all turned to see Shadow Weaver lurking in the doorway. Catra bit her lip. How much of that had she heard?

"Bravo. I must say, Adora, that was quite the performance."

The blonde backed off, moving to her friend's side. She idly reached for her hand, their fingers intertwining. "I'm sorry Shadow Weaver, I just-"

"Why don't apologize Adora, I encourage that kind of spirit here. Use that rage on the battlefield and you'll have no issue keeping up with our troops."

Adora smiled, her eyes gleaming in satisfaction. "I told you I've got your back." Adora whispered in Catra's ear. She smiled back at her.

"Now cadets, listen up," their mentor continued, "I have come to collect you all for dinner. Since you've all been successful in training lately," her eyes fixed on Catra, "or at least the majority of you- Lord Hordak and I set up a surprise for you."

Excited chatting spread about the group like wildfire as they made their way down the hall. "What do you think it could be?" Adora asked, practically prancing after Shadow Weaver.

Catra shrugged. "I hope its extra rations, especially if it's the grey kind. I'm starving!"

"I doubt that's what it is," Kyle spoke up from the end of the line, "The Horde never lets us eat more then the recommended amount of calories."

"Hmm, you're probably right." Adora noted. "Maybe we'll get some time away from training?"

Catra shook her head. "No way, they always say that our sole purpose here is training. We haven't got a single day off since we got here, not even when we were sick."

After a little while Shadow Weaver hushed them, demanding they walk the rest of the way in silence. "Children," she muttered, "sometimes I really wonder why I ever came here."

When they arrived at the cafeteria, they each grabbed their ration bar and sat down at the assigned benches. Adora pointed at a small black box sitting on one of the tables. "What do you think that is?"

"Is it some kind of bomb they brought back from battle?" Kyle guessed. "Are we going to blow stuff up!?"

Catra bounded over to it. She sniffed it for a good minute before finally shaking her head. "It's definitely not a bomb," she declared, "if it was, I'd smell chemicals on it."

"You're right, its not a bomb. And it certainly isn't for you." Shadow Weaver made her away over, pushing Catra aside.

"This device allows you to watch fellow humans performing on recordings called moving pictures."

Everyone's eyes grew huge. "We can see what other people are doing outside of the Fright Zone?" One of the student's asked.

"Does that mean we can spy on Etheria?" Another asked hopefully.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. "Unfortunately, no. Moving pictures are solely for the purpose of enjoyment. For every exam you pass, you will be able to watch one recording that you all will agree on. Those that fail," she once again looked at Catra, "will not join in on this reward and will instead eat dinner in their room."

Adora had a huge smile on her face. She turned to Catra, looking like she was about to burst into tears from happiness. "Isn't this amazing? The Horde never offered anything like this before!"

"Adora, there's something I should tell you." Catra stared at the floor.

"What is it?"

"I- I haven't been passing the tests lately. I've been- I won't be able to watch the movie."

"Oh Catra." Adora's face fell. "I thought you were going to tell me if you needed help with anything."

Catra lashed her tail. "Its not like its easy admitting to you that I'm a failure!"

"Catra no, you're not-" Before she could even finish what she was saying, her friend had taken off and out if sight.

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Catra lay in her bed sulking. The mattress was stiff and unfamiliar as she wasn't used to laying on her own bed. She usually just shared Adora's. But it didn't feel right for her to lay in her bed right now. It wasn't that she was mad at the girl. It was just that Adora was the most amazing person she knew. She was strong, loyal, compassionate, she even cared for a screw-up like herself. So to admit that she couldn't even keep up with her classes…

Catra used to be able to match the blonde in everything, from strength, to wit, to street smarts. But now? Now Shadow Weaver broke that part of her. She tried to keep the torment

hidden for Adora's sake, but she could hardly bear to keep it in. The things the masked woman did behind closed doors gave her nightmares, visions she could never escape, not even in the waking hours.

"Catra?"

The girl looked up to see her friend standing right beside her. "What are you doing here? Shouldn't you be doing homework with the group?"

Adora shook her head. "No, I left during dinner to do that."

Catra stared up at her in shock. "But the moving picture-"

"Wouldn't have been any fun without you."

"Adora, that was your reward for hard work. You shouldn't have skipped it for me."

"I didn't say that I totally skipped it." The blonde winked. "I'll be right back!" She ran out of the room only to return a few moments later, pushing a cart with the video machine on it. "I figured if Shadow Weaver wouldn't let you watch the moving picture during dinner. I'd just have to bring it up to you!"

Catra's voice was lost somewhere at the back of her throat. Adora went out of her way, risking getting into serious trouble, just to make sure Catra wasn't sad. She didn't know what to say how she felt about that, so she just ignored it. "What's the tape called?"

Adora showed her the case. Two people stood facing one another under an umbrella. The words 'A Reunion to Remember' were written along the top.

The two girls struggled to plug the box in. After a while they finally got it working and retreated to the blonde's bed. To Catra's relief she didn't have to deal with her stiff mattress any longer.

As the film rolled, Catra's eyes were glued to the screen. She wasn't particularly interested in the story, but the way she was able to see into somebody else's life fascinated her. As the moving picture progressed, she caught onto what was happening.

A man had to go away to war, leaving a woman behind. They wrote letters to one another, but for some reason they never made it to their destination. Thinking that the man was dead, the woman moved on with her life. It wasn't until the end that the man showed up at her doorstep with a bunch of flowers.

"Suzy!" The man on the screen called out in happiness. "I finally made it home to you, after all these years. Did you wait for

my, my love?"

The woman jumped into his arms. "Oh Daniel, I thought I lost you!" And then she proceeded to do the weirdest thing Catra had ever witnessed. She put her mouth against his.

"WHAT!?" Catra screamed, just as the credits appeared. "She missed him for like 10 years and the moment he gets home she tries to kill him with her germs?"

Adora scrunched her face up in deep thought. "I think I remember one of the older girl's mention something about face touching. She said people do it when they love someone. She called it kissing."

Catra cocked her head. "When you love someone, you spread your germs to them?"

"I guess its supposed to be not so gross when its with the right person. That's what the older kids said anyway."

"Oh." Catra said. Adora got up to turn the box off. She was ready to take it back downstairs when the brunette called out to her. "I love you. Does that mean we're supposed to kiss?"

"I guess so. I mean, I love you too." Adora made her way back over to her bed, sitting down in front of Catra. "Okay, let's

try it."

"Yeah, okay." Neither of them made any chance to move forward. "I think you're supposed to lean in. That's what the man did."

Adora nodded. Eyes still open, she leaned in. Her lips lightly pressed over Catra's. In a second it was over.

Catra let out an unsatisfied hum. "I don't get it." She stated blandly.

"Maybe- maybe we should close our eyes. Like they did on the box." Adora suggested. "If you want to try it again, I mean."

"Yeah, that's fine. But I'll lean this time." Catra said. She waited for Adora's eyes to close. Then she stared at her pretty face, with freckles spotted all over . She took in the sight of her blonde hair, so bright against everything dull in the Fright Zone. She wanted to keep this picture of her friend in her mind forever. Finally, she closed her eyes as well.

This time when she closed the distance, Catra saw what all the rage was about. She liked it, it felt nice. It felt like as long as her and Adora were together, nothing bad could ever happen. As long as they had each other, everything would be okay.

"Catra?"

"Hmm?"

"I think I like kissing you."

"Catra! CATRA!" *The familiar voice rang out as her memory faded. She actually was pissed to be thrown of that memory so quick. It was one of her favorites, from a time they we both so naïve, they didn't know what a relationship was. She loved the way Adora held her afterwards. She loved how after that the two of them would laugh whenever they caught the other's gaze in training, knowing they had a secret nobody else had. They were best friends and nothing could tear them apart. Except it had. She-ra had stolen her best friend away from her. Catra wanted her dead.* ***"DON'T FORGET!"*** *The voice commanded once more.*

That was all it had to say this time. She waited for it to say more. She waited until the pain of her last death returned. Finally, she gave up and she opened her eyes. She felt a heavy metal around her wrists.

She looked around in horror. Damn it! She was in Shadow Weaver's old cell!

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all so much for reading! I love seeing your comments, they encourage me to continue! Love you guys! *inserts hugs through the firewall* (If that's how a firewall works. I'm not entirely sure and I'm also half asleep so don't mind me) I'll see you guys next chapter!

Remember, I'll Always Be Here

Chapter Notes

TW: This chapter may contain thoughts of suicide. Please read with care.

Here we are guys. We're getting into the heart of Catra's pain. These next two chapters (4 and 5) are going to be a two part storyline. That means that the memories in the chapters will run together. The girls are about 16 in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Don't you get it?" Catra seethed. Purpled light shone around her, lighting up her pale face. It didn't show her pain or misery. In fact, it didn't reveal anything at all. For once she felt nothing. Adora had finally succeeded, she'd broken her. "I am never going to go with you!"

Not after what you've done to me.

The portal was supposed to make things go back to normal. Sure, it had also had a very real probability of blowing up the entire world, but what did it matter as long as this time she could die in her Adora's arms. But Adora didn't want her. Adora didn't need her. She wasn't going to stay no matter how desperately she wanted her to.

But that was fine. Catra didn't need her either.

When the blonde first left, she thought she'd simply die off without her there. Her entire life, Adora acted like she *needed* her to protect her. Catra was weak, she couldn't take care of herself. That's what she'd been told for her entire life, not only by her torturer, but also by her best friend.

But Catra now knew she was more than capable of surviving on her own. She'd made her way to force captain without any help from the others around her. She'd replaced Shadow Weaver as Hordak's second in command. Everyone below her, feared her. They ran whenever she came into sight. And now she brought the end of the world.

She was more powerful than anyone could have known. And it turns out that every time somebody had belittled her, they had poked little holes into Catra's shield. She had thought the shield protected her from the world, but as it turned out, it was protecting Etheria from her. And now that it was completely stripped away, there was nothing left to stop her from extracting her revenge.

She laughed at Adora's shocked face. What a sight it was to see her enemy heartbroken by actions she'd brought on herself. "You always have to go and ruin, don't you?"

Old promises rang into her ears; promises that were broken long ago, by the one who coward before her. *"I will never leave you Catra, as long as I'm alive."*

I won't let you hurt me anymore.

Adora was the one who had given her a name, a place in the Horde, a reason to live, even when everyone else despised her. Then, she'd taken it all away overnight, and here she was, begging Catra to forget all of that, to go *with* her. No. No more would anyone hurt her. If the end of the world got rid of any chance of pain, then by all means, bring it on.

So, as she once again found herself hanging off a ledge, she took one final look down. The portal would eat her alive. There would be no chance she would reincarnate into the soon to be empty void. For the second time in her life Catra jumped, knowing she was about to die.

"Catra! No!"

Her lithe body plummeted down into the purple abyss. Jolts of electricity worked its way into her very being. She felt as if she were being electrocuted time and time again.

"Aaaaghhhhh!" She cried out. No one could hear her. No one could help her.

Her mind started to go fuzzy as some sort of smoke reached her nose. She could no longer feel herself falling. Instead, it felt as if she was stuck floating in midair. A quick glance down showed her otherwise.

Out of nowhere a voice whispered in her ear. ***"I know you've forgotten Catra..."***

She gritted her teeth through the pain. "Stop harassing me!" She screamed. "I- It doesn't matter, just- just leave me alone! Leave me to die! Just like Adora and everyone else has!"

"You must remember the promise! Only then will all be fine!"

"WHAT PROMISE!" The noise around her was so loud that she could hardly hear herself speak. Trees were ripped up from the ground, buildings collided, everything was falling apart, just as she planned.

"REMEMBER! Remember the promise you made!"

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"Catra, are you in here?"

Catra slid further into the tub. She hated water with a passion, but she couldn't let Adora see her wounds. Lately she

had made a point of being the first one in the bath and the last one out. Somehow nobody had noticed. Well, that is, no one except for her best friend.

Adora peeked her head into the large bathroom. Her eyes landed on the girl scrunched up in the massive tub. It was built so all the kids in the group could bathe together, saving on the Horde's water usage.

The blonde made her way in, sitting beside her. "Okay, tell me what's going on?"

Their eyes met for a brief moment, before Catra drew hers away. "What do you mean? I'm just taking a bath."

"Exactly. You never get all the way in the tub."

"Shadow Weaver was really tough on us in training today. I was sweaty and felt gross, so obviously I wanted to clean myself!" She hissed, drawing away from the girl.

Adora's eyes ran over what parts of her body she could see through the soapy water. "We always sweat during training. Catra, I have never seen you in the water this long, no matter what exercises they put us through. Seriously, tell me what's wrong. I can help you."

"No one can help me Adora!" She extended her arm to slap her but stopped herself just as she noticed that her scars were visible. She could tell Adora saw them too. Her eyes grew wide, and she grabbed her friend's hand, revealing the full extent of damage.

"What happened?" Her words were quiet. Catra bit her lip, pretending she hadn't heard her.

"That's fine, don't tell me." Adora said, getting out of the tub. She extended her hand to the brunette. "But, at least let me take care of you."

Catra hesitated. If she were to get out of the water now, Adora would be able to see everything. She would find every bruise, every scar that evil woman physically placed on her body. She would find out her internal suffering.

She couldn't let her know. She was supposed to be the tough one, the one who could stand up for herself. If Adora saw her, she would never think the same of her.

"I said nothing is wrong Adora! Just leave me the fuck alone!" She yelled as loud as she could bare.

Her friend stared back at her blankly. "I- I just want to help. We're a team-"

“I don’t need you always up my ass! You know, I am capable of taking care of myself.”

“I know. But you don’t have to do it alone. Remember what I promised you? I'll always be here if you need me.” Slowly, Adora turned around. Without saying another word, she walked out of the bathroom.”

Great. Now Catra was a monster who just screamed at her best friend for no reason. She flexed her claws under the water, trying to relieve tension.

After deciding nobody else was coming to take a bath that night, Catra finally let herself stand up. Shaking her hair out, she made her way over to the mirror.

The first thing she noticed were her eyes. That’s what everyone saw when they first looked at her. They stood out, blocking anyone’s initial view from her pain below.

Her eyes skimmed over her stomach. A bright red gash stood out just on the left side of her belly button. That one had hurt bad. It was from when Shadow Weaver took a shard of broken glass to the girl as a form of punishment for not showing up on time. It had recently started to heal, but Catra hadn’t let it. She wanted it to scar. She wanted to keep the memory of pain fresh. It would help her in the future when she took that evil woman’s life.

She then looked lower, at the purple bruise extending up from her thigh to her chest. That one had been from being thrown against a wall for “disobedience” as Shadow Weaver had put it.

Then there were the small bruises; tiny marks she had been given that couldn’t easily be seen, but still hurt like hell. They were the woman’s favorite form of torture as she didn’t have to worry about any of the other kids noticing them.

Next were her arms; marred in both old scars and new. They bore the ones fresh from today, from when she had been bound.

What would Adora think if she’d seen her? Catra already knew the answer, she would be repulsed. So Catra would continue to hide them from her. It was truly for the best.

Grabbing her uniform from the towel rack, she got dressed. The fabric rubbed against her cuts, irritating them further. She took a deep breath as she felt the scab on her stomach break. She held a clawed hand over until the pain subsided a little.

It was fine. Everything was fine. Once Adora was force captain, they could get rid of Shadow Weaver. She just had to hang on a little longer.

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A zapping noise erupted inside her head. Her entire body felt as if it was asleep. When she opened her eyes, she noticed that only one was working correctly. The other flittered between seeing colors and black and white.

She had fallen into an empty void. So why, *why* was she still alive.

She struggled to stand up, her feet hardly able to support her. Just above her was the cliff she should have died on. Somehow, against all odds, it hadn't yet disappeared.

Her guttural scream filled the gully she was now standing in. It wasn't fair! Even when it came to Catra's choices, Adora always won. Well, no more. No more hesitating on her end. She was going to kill her former friend once and for all.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for reading, love you guys! Please let me know what you think below. Also would any of you be interested in me creating an Instagram to post concept art for my fanfics?

A Portal to the Past

Chapter Notes

Major TW for this chapter.
TW: Self-harm
Please be cautious reading this chapter. If you're not comfortable reading this, I will put a summery of what happened in the next chapter. Please all be safe. Love you guys

And I'm sorry for doing this to Catra. But at least you all know hoe She-ra ends (hugs)

P.S. I hope this chapter's not too confusing for you as it flashed between past and present often.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Something crackled inside of her head. The right side of her face burned as though she had lost it somewhere. She could hear someone walking with large, unsteady steps. She looked around, but nobody was there. She was alone in the cavernous gorge.

"Catra!"

She spun around so fast; she nearly fell over. That voice was so familiar and yet she couldn't name who it belonged to.

She hissed at the canyon around her. Apparently, her ears were playing tricks on her. Turning back around, she continued walking. There was something she needed to do. But what?

"Come sit with me!" A little blonde girl called out.

One moment Catra could see her as clear as the night, but in the next all she could see were the brown rocks surrounding her in the present world. What was going on? Where had the girl gone?

A noise popped in her head so loud, at first, she thought it had been thunder. She silently thanked anyone who was listening that it wasn't. There was nothing she hated more than water.

Catra could feel her feet changing direction. She didn't want to be anywhere near the blonde. Not after their last interaction.

Who was that girl?

ZzzaPpp! The noise in her ears crackled again.

Why was she avoiding her? Had the kid hurt her in some way.

She suddenly remembered last night; the tub, the scars, Adora demanding answers to uncomfortable questions. That was right, Adora was the blonde.

Catra lifted her shirt to reveal the extent of her injuries. Where she expected to find a fresh cut, was only a ghost of what used to be one. It ran up almost the entirety of one side. Why did she have to hide that from the girl? What was it anyway, a battle wound?

ZzzZZiippp! She shook her head, trying to clear out the static. The sound only got worse as she was jolted back into the cafeteria.

"I'm busy Adora, I have a lot of homework." She was surprised to find her mouth actually moving in the present.

"I have homework too! Maybe we can work on it together."

Catra stopped in her tracks, still holding her lunch tray. "I think I'd better do it on my own for now. That's what Shadow Weaver wants."

Shadow Weaver. Even now, back in the present, Catra tensed at the name. Her mind was still foggy, but she knew that had been the name of someone very cruel. Her hand unconsciously flew to her stomach at the thought.

Oh, that's right. Shadow Weaver was the one who had condemned her to nineteen years of torture. No wonder she hated her.

ZZzzzzzZZZZZzzZZ! Her tail lashed in agony. That one had been stronger than the others, as though the intensity was growing with each electric shock.

Catra sat down on the cold bathroom floor. She had to wait until she was certain everyone was asleep before coming in here to treat her wounds. There was no such thing as privacy in the Horde. They were told it was a luxury they could not afford.

She ran the damp toilet paper along the bloody cut on her stomach. She cringed as the tissue almost immediately turned a bright red. She dumped it in the toilet as she stood up.

She looked up at the ceiling, only to find a purple sky in its place. Where was the drop ceiling? It had just been there.

She stumbled over a rock while she wasn't looking, sending her to the ground. When she got back up, she found herself in a forest. Her heart stopped as she caught a glimpse of the blonde.

Adora, the little girl from her memories was here. And she was all grown up.

Every event of Catra's life unfolded right in front of her. She remembered her best friend, the betrayal she had caused, the grief that came along with it. She remembered the portal, sending Entrapta to Beast Island, she remembered doing her best to die. But she had failed. She was still alive and She-ra was going to try to save the world from collapsing.

Well, not if she could help it! After everything that happened, Etheria didn't deserve to see another day.

Clumsily Catra climbed onto the seat of the toilet. She reached her hands up high, pushing a piece of ceiling back. Dust fell into her eyes, temporarily clouding her vision. She just had to reach a little further in. Her fingertips felt around until they grabbed hold of the box. Then she slowly worked it out.

She smirked. Adora was distracted. This would be too easy. She pressed one finger to the girl's temple.

"HeeEeeYyyy Adooraaaa." Her voice sounded robotic against the chaos in her head.

This is what she's done to me. She couldn't help but smirk. She grabbed her head, pushing her back. They were sent back into another room. She stood stock still for a moment, taken aback by the sudden change of scenery. Then her eyes narrowed, and she found herself lunging forward again.

"Where are your friends now?" She heard herself asking as though from a trance. She was fighting, but she could hardly tell what was happening before being forced back in time.

The box was lighter in her hands then she remembered. She sat back down, taking off the lid. She dug through scraps of papers until she found what she was looking for. She took out one of the band aids to place on her stomach. When she was satisfied, she put the wrapper back with the other trash occupying the container.

It wasn't fair. She was the only one in the Horde that was treated like this. Adora didn't have to dress her own wounds, injuries that shouldn't have even been. The only times the other kids got hurt was during training.

She was completely alone here. Even if she had Adora, the girl would never know what she was really going through. And that was completely Catra's fault. If she just told her… but the fact was that she couldn't. She wasn't strong enough or brave enough. She made up the story that Adora couldn't handle it. But really, it was Catra who hadn't been able to deal with it.

In a haze a confusion and despair, she reached back into the little box. Snowmen were holding hands on the outside, as it had been a Christmas cookie tin, she'd 'borrowed'. She felt around until she felt metal.

"Catra stop!"

She looked up. This wasn't supposed to happen, not yet. Adora wasn't supposed to see her actually- but no. It wasn't past Adora. This was in the present. Adora wasn't here to save her this time. She was here to kill her.

She hissed, throwing her ex-friend backwards, hitting every inch of her body that she could reach. She kicked her, making the girl collapse on the bridge. "If you hadn't found the sword and been the world's worst She-Ra none of this would have happened!"

Adora bowed her head. 'Yes! Now you see yourself for what you really are! You aren't a hero Adora. You're the monster who left when you knew how much I needed you!' Well, not anymore!

A sharp pain ran from her wrist to her elbow. She clutched it in pain. Blood welled up at once, bubbling out of the cuts she had just given herself. No! What had she done? Shadow Weaver would show her no mercy for this weakness. She grabbed some more tissues to try and stem the bleeding. It just soaked through the light fabric, dripping onto the floor.

Her breathing grew ragged as she fumbled to find a band-aid, holding the offending hand to her chest all the while. Finally finding one, she wobblily walked over to the sink. Was it just her nerves or was she growing fainter by the second?

“Admit it! The world would still be standing if you had never come through that portal in the first place!” As soon as she spoke the words, she regretted them. They were harsh, Catra knew that. And maybe, maybe the blame shouldn’t lie all on Adora but-

NO! Static filled her head until she couldn’t hear herself think. All of this was Adora’s fault! If she had just stayed with Catra this fiasco would never have happened, she knew in her heart she was right about that. They would have ruled over Etheria. They would have been happy.

She dunked the girl in the icy water, before sending them somewhere else. “You made me this!” She cried, unleashing every ounce of pent-up emotion. “You took everything from me!” She pushed the girl back onto the seat of the spaceship. Adora stared at her in undisguised horror. “You broke the world, and it is all your fault!”

She could see the exact moment the girl snapped. Her eyes grew wide with fury. She leapt at Catra, pushing her back. “No, it’s not!” She screamed.

Catra almost laughed at her little fit of rage. That was, until she noticed the were back near the edge of nothing. Adora had done this on purpose. She had lured her here to push her off the cliff.

"I didn't make you pull the switch!"

Catra growled, trying to claw the girl's eyes out. Adora caught her arm and in turn, flung her backwards. "I didn't make you do anything!"

"I didn't break the world. But I am gonna fix it." She yelled with an intensity that surprised the brunette. "And you? You made your choice."

She tried once more in vain, to get an attack in. Adora punched her so hard she flew to the unsteady ground.

"Now live with it!" As the ground caved in, Catra didn't get up. She couldn't. Everything had just been too much for her.

She knew what was coming, even before it happened. She anticipated to burning, the sound of overpowering static. She had been through this same death only a short time before. And it still hurt just as bad, if not worse when her body was eaten alive by the void.

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Warm water washed the red away from her arm. She turned it off, only to have the red bubble back right away. "No," she whispered to herself. She fell to her knees, no longer able to hold herself up. "I didn't mean to."

What would Adora think when she found out in the morning? Would she be the one to discover her body? She would think she had done it on purpose. Catra couldn't let that happen.

"Adora." She tried to scream, but she just didn't have the energy. She rolled onto her stomach, crying out as her cut made contact with the floor. Slowly she crawled out of the bathroom and into the kid's bunker. "'Dora." She moved one hand after another until at last, she made it to the foot of Adora's bed. She grabbed the blanket and weakly tugged. "'Dora."

"Mmm, Catra, go back to sleep."

"Please," she whispered, her voice hardly making its way to the other girl. "I made a big mistake. I didn't mean to but-"

As soon as she registered the urgency in Catra's voice, she sat straight up. She frantically looked around the room until her eyes landed on the small shape curled up on the floor. "Catra?"

A lamp flickered on as Catra lay there waiting for the screaming. "Oh! Oh, oh um, oh Catra!" She shrieked, her eyes landing on the trail of blood leading from the bathroom to the girl. She jumped down beside her, cradling her body. "Okay, its okay. You- I need to get- Help! Someone help her!"

"Ssshhh!" She tried to quiet her.

It was too late. Lonnie had already heard them and came rushing over. "Oh my god! What happened!"

Catra's world grew dark. The faces around her turned into unfamiliar shapes, growing fuzzier and fuzzier with time.

"I don't know, I found her like this. H- help me get her to the bathroom. There has to be something we can use in there."

"Kyle! Kyle, get as many clothes as you can find and bring them to me!"

She felt her body being lifted from the floor. She couldn't tell if someone was picking her up or if this is what dying felt like. After a minute something cold pressed against her back, followed by a tight fabric being wrapped around her arm.

"Okay, that should stop the bleeding."

"Is she going to be okay?"

"Shut up Kyle, we don't know right now."

"I still don't get it. What happened?"

"She tried to take her own life." That was Adora's voice. She knew that's where her mind would go, but to hear it out loud stung. Catra would never do anything like that on purpose. She was stronger than that.

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"Hey, good morning sleepy head."

Catra's eyes opened to meet Adora's. She looked around to find all the other kids still asleep. "What time is it?" She croaked, her voice hoarse from last nights events.

"Its about 10." Adora whispered, bringing the blanket higher on Catra's body. "We all faked being really sick and contagious so they would leave us alone today. Shadow Weaver was so pissed!" She forced a laugh.

"Oh." Catra shut her eyes, pulling away from Adora.

"Catra, I don't know what happened last night and I don't expect you to tell me right away. But I need you to know that I'll always be here for you. I love you so, so much, okay?"

Okay. I love you to Adora. And I'm sorry."

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Everything was bright and absolutely perfect when Catra came back to life. There was no trace that the portal ever existed. She-ra had saved the world, against her best efforts.

Catra should probably go attack her once more. It would be the perfect timing, right when she was relaxed. But she didn't want to. Not yet. Right now all she wanted to do was sleep. She could always cause another war tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

So yeah, that was intense. I'm sorry for doing that to you guys. I promise the next chapter will be lighter. I should have it up by either Monday or Tuesday night. Thanks for reading and please let me know what you think below.

Can You Feel My Pulse?

Chapter Notes

Hey guys, it's me back with another hard chapter. TW for all the usual along with depictions of rape and such harm. Catra is in a really dark place right now, so please don't think she's right with her thoughts. Take care all, love you tons!

Electricity forced its way into Catra's body. She couldn't speak, couldn't breathe. The world felt like it was crashing down around her, and perhaps it was. Chunks of the ceiling came crashing down along with the poles that once held the building up. Dust flew everywhere, making it so that she couldn't see.

The ruckus didn't stop Sparkles though. She just kept coming, zapping her powerful streams of magic into Catra. Her body convulsed as she hit the wall with an inhuman force.

'I just need to get up. As long as I have my bot I can get away.' She pounced to her feet, darting away. The damn princess was too quick though. She just walked along after her.

"Where are you going Catra? Not scared of some sparkles, are you?" She laughed wickedly.

This was what Adora chose over her friendship? This girl was hardly any better than she was. At least Catra was blunt about what she needed to do. She didn't switch between personalities like *her.*

Catra was too weak to put up much more of a fight. This girl, the one Adora had left her for, was about to kill her. It had all happened too fast, there was no way to prevent this situation from happening, not when Double Trouble reported the Rebellion being in a totally different location.

She leapt onto the robot's panel, hands hovering over the buttons. "The pulse bots are out vaporizing your 'friends', but I bet you'd like to see our upgrade." She slammed her fist down, bringing the enormous machine to life. "We were saving it for a special occasion, but I guess this'll have to do." Because she knew, if it didn't, she would be dead. She only had four more lives; she couldn't afford to throw any more away.

The fire burned brighter as the bot's vibrations brought even more rubbage down. She grinned widely at the queen's horrified face.

"You're gonna bring the whole place down!"

"Don't worry," Catra mocked, "I'm not planning to stick around." She nimbly leapt over the girl's head. "It's revving up to send up a pulse to level half of the woods. So you better **choose**, me or the bot."

Catra ran without looking back. Her eyes were so focused on the exit that she didn't see the cage-like plank coming loose

from above. She let out an ear-splitting screech as it fell on top of her.

Her bones cracked under it like twigs, and she felt her lungs collapse under the excruciating weight. “Aaah…” She moaned.

“Guess now I don’t have to choose.”

Catra struggled for air, but it wouldn’t reach her chest. She tried to break free from the metal bars. She pulled and pulled until her fingers bled. The next few moments were a complete blur as she finally had no choice but to give into her sixth life.

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“CAAATRAA!” *Air rushed into her ears, fogging up her brain. It had been a while since the strange voice had made its appearance.*

‘ No. No, not you again.’

“Catra! Do you remember?” *Of course not. It was still as ominous as ever.*

‘ What?’

"DO YOU REMEMBER YET!?"

'I thought you wanted me to remember the promise Adora made?' She argued internally. 'The promise that she would never leave me?'

The voice had gone though, leaving her in the void. Any moment she would be swept back into another memory. She stood there, in the empty white space, waiting for the scenery to change. It didn't though.

A light flashed somewhere ahead of her. 'May as well follow it,' she decided, 'it's not like I have any where else to go.'

As she walked toward the flashing light, two holographic figures stood in front of her. She recognized them right away. It was her and Adora; of course, it was always her and Adora. They had never gone through a day without each other, until she was abandoned.

She watched as the girls played through the white area around her. Why was this so different from her normal memories? Usually when they happened, she lived it over again through her childhood self.

"Adora, get back here!" The little translucent Catra called after her friend.

"No way!" Adora laughed. "I want to see what you write in this thing."

Ah. This was the day that Adora found her secret hiding space in the bathroom. It was stupid to keep a notebook with her thoughts, but still, it had been cruel of Adora to invade her privacy.

"Adora, please, I beg you! Give it back!" Tears formed in Catra's eyes. Adora seemed to sense this as she stopped dead in her tracks. She took one look at her friend's teary eyes before reaching to hand back the little black notebook.

"I'm sorry. That was really wrong of me."

Just as Catra grabbed onto the thick paper, it was ripped from her hands. She looked up to find Shadow Weaver now clutching onto her handwritten words.

The two girls helplessly stared as Shadow Weaver flashed her most wicked smile. "Now, lets see what miss Catra 'Applesauce' is wasting her time on now.

Just like that, all three figures disappeared. She took a cautious step forward, fearing what she would find. A bed appeared on her left side.

Narrowing her eyes, trying to see better, she slowly made out a shape sitting rigid. It was a young girl, maybe sixteen. Catra couldn't exactly remember when all of this had happened. She'd done her best to shove this day as far back as she could.

The girl played with her fingers, counting each one as a way to calm her nerves. After all Shadow Weaver had learned her deepest darkest secret. Surely there would be hell to pay.

And what hell it ended up being… Catra could feel her body tense as the door creaked open. A figure loomed almost seven feet tall. It glared at the girl with such ferocity that it could kill.

"Catra," It spat. "Show me your arms. Now!"

The girl hesitantly lifted her sleeves. Shadow Weaver grabbed her arms roughly.

Catra turned away from the scene that was playing out. It was the day when Shadow Weaver first- no, she wouldn't think of that. Not now, not ever.

The woman grabbed her roughly, irritating the already sore marrs that covered her skin. "You little bitch!" She hissed, slapping the girl across the face.

Catra's hand reached up to her cheek. "Wha- "

"You ungrateful bitch, taking pity on yourself. You have had nothing but a good life filled with too many second chances here! And to find out that this is what you've been doing! Well starting today I'll make you see what actual pain is!"

Catra struggled as a pair of insanely strong hands pushed her into the mattress. "Hey!" She screamed. "What are you doing? What are you ***Mmffm!****"*

Her words were interrupted by Shadow Weaver covering her mouth with a gag. "Shut up you stupid slut."

Catra turned her back on her younger self. She'd lived that day more times than she could count. She didn't need to see that again.

Her own muffled cries rang out as she walked away from the translucent memories. They carried all the way to the next scene, where she was lying on her bed. She saw herself staring at a vase of daisies. They were withering in this prison, much like herself.

She grabbed one between her fingers, studying the dark petals. It was probably in so much pain. If she just- She crushed the flower in her hand, then watched as the broken parts fell onto the ground. Now it was free. It would never have to feel pain again.

There was a light knock on the door. Catra had never felt such fear and yet she couldn't get herself to move. What did it matter anyway? Shadow Weaver could find her wherever she hid.

"Catra? I'm coming in, okay." She let a sigh of relief out as she heard her friend's voice. She was safe, at least for now.

She watched as the door opened and the blonde made her way in. She was carrying a plate full of food in her hands. "You missed dinner again."

Catra rolled onto her side, facing away from Adora. "I wasn't hungry."

She felt a pressure on her bed. She sat straight up, lashing a clawed hand at her friend. She watched Adora's face in shock as blood pooled on her cheek.

"Catra, I-"

Catra stood up and walked away from her. "Just leave me alone."

"Alright." She heard footsteps retreating.

'Good job Catra, not only did you hurt your best friend, but you chased her away after too.'

She waited for the sound of the metal door to close. When it never did, she turned around to see why. Adora was still there, sitting on the floor. "What?"

Adora met her heterochrome eyes. "I'll leave you alone, but I won't leave you. I'll always be here for you Catra.

My destiny lies with you

Chapter Notes

Guess who's finally back after dropping off of the world of AO3! Me with another cringey and angsty chapter!

TW for suicidal idealization and brief mentions of rape

A fiery bomb tore through the dark sky as a chunk of the building was demolished. Catra's small body flew backwards, not able to stand the force of the blast's radius. She hit the ground hard, her shoulder nearly crushed under her own weight.

"Hordak, whatever you're doing," she attempted to reason with him.

His arm aimed at her, the cruel robotic part of his body promising her demise. When he spoke, his voice was dangerously low. "I know about Entrapta!"

Catra was quick to rise, even while she couldn't open one of her eyes. She hated feeling powerless lying on the floor, when this monster hovered over her, ready to end her seventh life at any moment. "Entrapta was a traitor!" She insisted, her body convulsing with pain." What else is there to know?"

"I TRUSTED YOU!" Hordak seethed. He revved up his gun-arm for another attack. This time Catra was able to dodge it, but just barely.

She escaped into the hallway, running for her life. She had witnessed plenty of his executions, each one more grisly than the last. She didn't want to endure that utter torture. And if he somehow figured out about her nine lives, he wouldn't just let her go after she was reincarnated. He'd kill her over and over again until there was no life left in her soul.

"You're days were numbered the moment you crossed me!" He growled, marching forward.

Another burst of flames singed the tips of her hair. She leapt out of the way and into the Black Garnet Chamber, Shadow Weaver's old room.

Still Hordak kept coming, no matter how far she ran. "After I'm through with you, you can't even begin to imagine the punishments Horde Prime will inflict upon you."

Catra emerged from behind a stone pillar, giving a deprecating laugh. "Oh, because he's going to swoop down and fix everything for you at any moment, right? You're just lying to yourself now!" She hissed.

Hordak let out an unintelligible noise, as he fired his gun once more. This particular strike brought down half of the room. Catra almost found herself crushed beneath the rubble, only narrowly escaping. The ceiling creaked wickedly, daring anyone to get under its warpath.

Catra scampered up high onto a platform, trying to dodge each relentless blast. She could almost taste her heart as it rose up in her throat. She was growing tired, her maimed body starting to give out on her.

She looked around for a way to escape. Maybe if she could just keep him talking, then she could get out. That way, even if she did die, it wouldn't be anywhere he could find her body. Afterall there was a lot of rubble from the demolished building.

"Why would Horde Prime care about you?" She hissed. The words came out too easily, sounding far too similar to the ones she had thought everyday since she was left alone. Why would Adora care about me? "You're a defect, a mistake." All too true to her own situation, her voice echoed around her head. 'She left you because you weren't good enough.'

She shook her head, trying to wipe Adora from her mind. "Haven't you noticed? I'm the one running things here."

Hordak shot a laser at her, bringing more of the foundation crumbling to the ground. Catra leapt onto some loose wiring to free herself of the torment of the wicked flames. At the last second, she swung herself straight at him and kicked him in the mouth. The robotic man fell to the ground under the flurry of attacks.

Finally, she found herself standing over his weak body. “Now we can finally end this.” She spat. “I didn’t need Entrapta. I didn’t need Adora or Scorpia.” She howled, her body still shaking without her even realizing it. “And I don’t need you!”

Just as he tried to get to his feet, she lunged at him one final time. Her claws landed on the runestone in his chest. As she tore it out, he let out one final anguished cry. Then, without warning, he stopped screaming. He wickedly grinned, seeming to stare into her soul.

Catra froze in place. That wicked smile told her everything. He had a plan. He knew what he was doing from the moment he asked to speak with her.

How could she have been so stupid? She missed all the signs. He lured her right into his trap.

She readied herself to start running again. His gun started to emit that all too familiar red glow.

Glancing over her shoulder, she tried to find the best escape route, but she was now backed into a corner. There was nowhere to go, with he collapsed building now taking over most of the small room.

Right as he was about to step forward and put an end to the Magicat, the ceiling caved in. It fell, crushing Hordak under its

impossible weight, getting rid of his tyranny forever.

When the dust settled there was no trace of the former Horde leader. Catra started to maniacally cackle, for the first time starting to feel free.

There was no more Hordak. No more Shadow Weaver, or Adora around telling her what to do, how to act. She was in charge now. And once she got rid of She-ra, no one would be left to ever hurt her again.

Perhaps, after the war, she could return to the Crimson Waste. She had liked it there, the feeling of anyone bending to her will. She could build her own fortress, form her own band of mismatched recruits. Sure, Scorpia had since joined the rebellion, but she was positive she could persuade her to come back. For after She-ra was dead, where would all the so-called refugees go?

A sudden pain in her chest brought her out of her reverie. She rubbed a hand above her left breast, where she found a tear in her shirt. Lifting it to her face, she found a long streak of scarlet now covering her flesh.

She brought her gaze down to see a massive puncture wound through her ripped clothing. A shard of metal haphazardly protruded out of it. ‘How had I not noticed that?’ she berated herself. Her adrenaline must have had her so pumped up that she hadn’t realized when she’d been hit.

"Ahhahhaha," she laughed, terrified of what was going to come next. Another memory of torture was sure to plague her mind. A memory that she had no control over. She knew what one was coming next, since nothing good happened after Shadow Weaver's rape. For years, she had tried to shove that hell to the very back of her mind, to be forgotten. But her unconscious brain, seemed to never let her rest.

She reached out a hand to the wall, trying to steady herself. Her knees buckled and she could barely breath as if the very air refused to work with her. She rested her hands on the ground for support as a wave of nausea hit and her vision started to blur. Catra knew all too well, these were the tell-tale signs of dying.

She tried to make it to her feet. She had to hide before anyone found her in here. She would be totally vulnerable if she didn't move. "Ahah!" She chocked, trying to get a breath of the dusty air.

Catra picked up a leg to walk and instantly tumbled back to the ground. Even walking was just too much for her at this point. Still, she refused to just give up. She started to crawl as if her life depended on it and perhaps it did. Her palms bled as the debris from the building tore into the delicate flesh. 'A little bit further,' she told herself.

She almost made it to the pile of rubble that entrapped Hordak too, but just as she got there, black took over her vision. Now blind, she was completely helpless. Her arms gave way, and her head smacked against the ground hard.

"Help. Me." Were her final words before death overtook her once more.

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Children screamed in the field, but she paid them no heed. It was just background noise to Catra, a murmur of the lives that had started to move on without her. Everything seemed to be moving at the speed of light, while she was stuck on an endless wheel, just trying to find a way to get off.

What did it matter what her teammates were doing anyway? Its not like she would make a difference to anyone. She was completely useless.

Once, a very long time ago, Catra had been one of the Horde's most promising Cadet's. Those that knew her would label her as a fierce and loyal friend, a truly worthy opponent. Hell, she could even kick Adora's ass if she wanted to.

But that life had crumbled away, leaving a shell of a girl in its place. She truly felt as if nothing mattered anymore. She had no hope for the future, no fears of the past. She simply existed.

If you had asked her several years ago what the worst feeling was, she would have said agony. Afterall, they were always taught that torture was the worst form of pain.

But she knew better than that now. Now that this utter numbness racked her body and mind… this by far took the top of that list.

"Catra, watch out!" She heard someone yell. She slowly looked up to see a bullet coming straight for her. She stared at it with a dead look, not caring to move.

No, Catra wasn't suicidal. It's not like she had a plan in place. She just didn't care if she died anymore. What was there to live for? More pain at Shadow Weaver's hands.

The bullet came closer and closer as she readied herself for impact. She didn't flinch even as it came nearly a foot away from her head. She was prepared to die. But at the last second, something pushed her to the ground and away from danger.

"Catra! Catra, what happened?" Adora screamed. Her blue eyes looked furious. Catra just looked into them with that same dead stare that she had looked at the bullet with. Should she feel bad that she could have gotten herself killed? Why? Who cared anyway? Adora would be better off without her in the way of things.

"You need to take this more seriously! If this was a real battle one of us would be dead!" The girl yelled, revealing the rubber bullet that had hit her arm when she shoved her friend out of the way.

“Adora, I didn’t mean-“

From the doorway, someone cleared their throat. Catra looked up and locked her gaze with Shadow Weaver. The woman grinned at the sight of her lying underneath Adora. “Well, well, well,” she hummed, marching closer. “Why, even I’m surprised about how absolutely ignorant you are child.”

Adora leapt to her feet, reaching a hand out for Catra. The girl silently took it and stood next to her blonde friend.

“Ma’am,” Adora acknowledged her captain.

Shadow Weaver glanced down at the rubber bullet. “Adora,” she drawled out calmly, “I know you weren’t just risking your life to save this pitiful creature, hmm?”

“It was just practice Shadow Weaver. In a battle-“

“You would be dead, all because of your little pet.” The cruel woman finished.

Adora simply bowed her head, saying nothing.

"Oh, Catra," Shadow Weaver reached out her hand, running her fingers through the girl's mane. Her nails got stuck for a moment, but she quickly yanked them down and out of the tangles. "I believe me and you have some unfinished business to discuss."

Catra kept her eyes trained on the floor, not daring to speak.

"Come," the woman hissed, urging Catra to follow, as she made her way out of the door.

* *

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'Did I ever have a purpose in this world?

'Was it just a dream I once gave myself?

'Sometimes if I close my eyes, I can still imagine that carefree child who ran through the halls playing tag with her friend. Sometimes I can look at my skin and remember a time that it was not all marked up.

'Sometimes I remember the feelings of love I once had for Adora. She was supposed to be the one I shared everything with. Not anybody else. And certainly not Shadow Weaver.

‘But that’s all been taken away now. Because most days, when I look at myself in the mirror, I see exactly what everybody else sees; the stupid whore that they said I was.

‘Perhaps I was never meant to be more than this.’

The paper crumbled under Catra’s claws as she tore it to shreds. She was careful now to not leave any traces of her monologues. She couldn’t let anyone see this side of her, after all that’s how this hell she lived in started. With a stupid notebook.

She walked the scraps of paper into the bathroom, pulling her box out from the hidden spot in the drop-ceiling. Inside lie all of her old memories. She spread its contents on the floor, hoping to find the sense of peace they once brought her.

At the very bottom there was the old movie case from all those years ago. No one had noticed when it never returned to the box of films. Afterall, Shadow Weaver had forbidden the moving pictures when she had found out that Adora brought them upstairs for Catra to watch.

But even with the punishments she had to deal with, it hadn’t been enough to make Catra regret that night. So, she kept that case to remember her love for Adora.

Next, she found an old bottle cap. When the cadets were little, they had secretly stayed up through some nights to play games. This came from the time they had played 'spin the bottle.'

Being kids that grew up isolated from the rest of the world, they never knew the correct rules to the games they played, only the basics. They made it up as they went along.

So, when the bottle swung to face Adora, she decided that she didn't want to kiss Kyle. Instead, she had leaned over the bottle and kissed the only person that she really wanted to. After the initial shock had worn off, Catra melted into her best friend's embrace.

It hadn't mattered that they weren't the only ones in the room this time. They had loved each other and that made the situation seem completely normal to them.

Catra hadn't been able to steal the bottle without suspicion at the end of the night, but she had been able to sneak the cap away. She'd then tucked it away with the rest of her prized possessions.

Next, she picked a delicate leather bracelet. Adora had made these for the two of them years ago, stealing the material from Hordak's very own weaponry. He had been so pissed to find the hilts of his swords ruined, but he had never been able to figure out who had done it. The girl's had been very careful to not let anyone see them.

All these memories and so many more, lost to the fate of time. Where had everything gone so wrong?

A gentle knock rattled the door. Catra glanced back at it. “Hang on, I’ll be out in a minute!”

“Catra, it’s me,” Adora spoke softly.

The girl stiffened. “Oh. Hey, Adora.”

“Listen,” something slid down the door, she presumed it was her friend, leaning back against it. “I know something has been bothering you. And- look, I don’t expect you to tell me what it is.” Her voice sounded so tired, it pained Catra’s heart. “But just know, however far apart we are, I will always be here for you.”

Always…

No matter what. Because Catra and Adora were a team, and they would be there for each other through the thick and thin.

Now you remember…

Catra squinted against the blinding light as she was shoved out of her dream-like trance. 'That? What does that matter? It's just an old promise that doesn't mean anything.'

You and Adora are two halves of a whole.

'What the fuck is that supposed to mean! I am NOT Adora, and she most certainly is not me!'

One cannot be complete without the other.

'Shut up! You don't know what you're talking about! And I don't even know who you are or what you want from me!'

I want you to remember the promise Catra.

'Shut up! Shut up! Shut up!' She tried to fight against the raging headaches the voice caused as it echoed around the emptiness surrounding her. Just leave me alone! Let me go back to the real world so I can get these last two lives over with! That way I'll never have to deal with you again.'

She pinched her arm, trying to wake herself up. When that didn't work, she bit her tongue hard, making it bleed. She let out a pained howl.

The voice seemed to mock her, repeating her anguished cry like a siren. On and on it went, so long that Catra could hardly deal with her headache any longer.

And just as it became unbearable, it was over, and Catra woke up in the destroyed Fright Zone.

Empty Corridors

Chapter Notes

We're getting pretty close to Catra's last life guys. This may be a hard chapter to read as there's some heavy stuff mentioned. Stay safe.

TW for Mentions of eating disorders, mutilation, mentions of rape, and torture.

As always, please only read if the subject matter doesn't bother you.

xc

"Do one good thing in you're life," the voice echoed in Catra's mind as she struggled to sleep. She pulled the picky blanket up, over her head. The lights never shut off in the ship, so she had no idea what the time actually was, but there was a tiredness deep in her bones that never seemed to go away.

'What does she know' Catra asked herself. *'I've done plenty of good things in my life and they all led me here.'*

For starters there was the time that she'd made Adora the ration bar cake- but no, that was just the weird portal reality. But surely there were other things. Like when she'd let Adora escape the Fright Zone, not because she liked her, but just because- because she didn't want her to come back…

Catra sat up in her bed and rubbed her eyes. For so long she had managed to convince herself that she was doing the right

thing. And perhaps she was. But what if it was only the right thing for herself? What if the war she had helped to create benefitted no one, but herself? What if the only thing she was fighting for any longer was to prove to herself that she was stronger than Adora? Had she made an enemy out of her best friend only because she couldn't control her jealousy?

On wobbly feet, Catra made her way out of the spare room she was staying in. She walked until she made it to Prime's trophy room. There, she hesitated before she entered.

The room was filled wall to wall with garments and gadgets from now extinct planets, from people who died in a war they never knew was coming. Helmets hung from the one side of the room, each varying from each other, based off of the shape of the people who had worn them. Some were big with large, ornate horns. Other were tiny, small enough for a cat to wear. But there was one in particular that caught her eye.

She picked it up and examined it close. It was about the size of her own head, and it was old and dusty, but she could tell that it was an off-white color. Its hard surface had a crack that ran through it from the very top to the cheek area. There it was met with a smudge of red that had never worn off.

Catra let out a screech as she realized what it was. It fell to the floor, smashing into a billion pieces, each a fragment of what used to be a human skull.

As she fell to the floor with the human helmet, she felt tears rise up in her eyes. For the first time she realized the true atrocities of Horde Prime. How could she support a creature of such evil?

If she didn't stop Adora from coming, would this be her skull lying here, forever forgotten? She hadn't cared about Prime killing her former friend, but this? He wouldn't just murder her, he'd mutilate her. And as twisted as Catra's soul had become, she could never stomach the thought of that happening to anyone, let alone someone she once had cared for so deeply.

"*-just know, however far apart we are, I will always be here for you."* Something snapped in her mind as Adora's words came back to her, clear as day.

From where they stood right now, Catra had never been farther from her friend. They were worlds apart both figuratively and realistically. And yet, there was something still inside her, that refused to let go of the idea that maybe some way, somehow, they were still connected to each other through a bond, neither of them quite understood.

"I will always be here for you," Catra whispered, rising back up. She wiped away the remaining tear drops from her eyes. "No matter how far apart we are." And just like that, she knew what she had to do. She had to end this. Glimmer was right. She needed to do the one good thing in her life. She needed to save her best friend. Not She-ra who had left her. She was forever gone, destroyed with the sword. No, she had to save her Adora.

* * *

She grinned as Hordak's face went blank. Step 1: eliminate the guards- complete. That just left… everything else.

"I'm coming in!" She hissed as she shoved the clone's hand against the door. It opened to reveal Sparkles poised and ready to attack. She eyed Catra with confusion. "What are you-"

Catra let Hordak fall to the floor, underneath her, where he belonged. "I… I want to do that one good thing in my life," she extended a clawed hand to the queen, "like you said."

Her eyes widened as if she hadn't expected her words to actually hold any meaning to the Magicat. Her jaw looked as if it was ready to drop by the time she let herself grab her hand.

Catra gave her a single nod, before dragging her out into the labyrinth of the ship. She recklessly tore through the halls, making their way to the launch pad. There was no time to waste. She only had one shot at this. If she failed, Adora would die an unimaginable death. This would all be for nothing.

"What are you doing?" Glimmer asked over the blaring sirens. They had made their way into the ejection channel and the queen had been placed in the shoot.

Catra typed fast, shutting all the exits from the room. "What does it look like?" She snapped, "I'm getting you out of

here.” The doors made their way closed ever so slowly. She nodded, satisfied with her quick work. “Good, that should hold them.” At least until she got Sparkles out of here.

“What are you? Are you saving me?” Glimmer gasped, as if finally realizing what was happening.

Catra typed something into the keyboard in an effort to contact the Etherian ship. “Not you, Adora.” “Even if I send her a message to stay away, she’d still come for you. That’s just how she is.” She never gave up on her friends. She wouldn’t. Even after all this time, Adora was still trying to reach her.

It tore her heart in two as the realization finally hit her like a ton of bricks. Because if Adora wasn’t the bad guy in this story, that meant Catra had been hating her for nothing.

The more she thought back to the night that Adora left, she remembered the blonde begging her to run away with her. And with the fear of what Shadow Weaver could do to her if she found out she left, Catra had refused. She’d chosen to stay with her tormentor, over moving on with her best friend. Adora hadn’t abandon her. Catra had abandon Adora.

Her heart nearly jumped out of her throat when the clones started to pry open the door. One of them managed to slip a finger through, but just a quickly, the metal closed around it. She almost gagged at the squelching sound that emitted from the brutally injured clone. It wouldn’t be long before one of them successfully got in. Prime had designed them so that they would

never back down from a fight, even if it meant they were going to get themselves killed.

"What about you?" Glimmer cried from the barrier that divided the two girls. One- an embodiment of the goodness in the world, and the other- the exact replica of evil. Or at least that was what Catra saw when she took a good look at everything around them.

"Me?" She scoffed. "All I do is hurt people. There's no one left in the entire universe who cares about me."

No one. Because this time she had gone too far. Not even sweet, perfect Adora would want her now. She was broken, she had been for a long time. The only difference was that now there was no one out there that gave her the tiniest thought. She'd doomed herself to this when she'd shut everyone out. It was what she deserved.

Static broke its way through the screen. "Adora?"

"Catra?" An all too familiar voice called out.

Behind her, she heard the door creaking open. The clones would be upon her soon. "Don't sound so happy to hear me. I'm sending Glimmer to you."

"Wait what? Glimmer is with you?" Adora asked.

Finally, the doors gave way and a sea of Prime's monsters poured in. Their hands reached out to grab her. But she wouldn't let them. Not yet.

"We don't have time! You need to get to these coordinates now!" She typed the location into the computer, "don't come here! No matter what!" She chocked out, punching the nearest clone in the face. "Horde Prime is coming for you!"

"Catra I don't understand What is….?"

The clones grabbed a hold of her, trying to take her back to their master. "Adora! I'm sorry!" She made one final leap forward, hitting the eject button and releasing Glimmer from the stronghold. "For everything!"

As soon as she'd finished speaking, one of the clones cut the wires, ending the transmission. Catra let herself go limp in their arms, knowing there was no use in fighting. She had already won. Adora was safe. That was all that mattered.

* *
*

The sound of beeping blared through Catra's overstimulated mind. She hung loosely from the wall, supported

only by her shackled wrists. She felt the unforgiving metal pierce through her skin, tearing apart her sensitive flesh.

She tried to look around, but her eyelids wouldn't fully open. They felt to heavy for her to keep raised. So, she gave way to sleep once more.

Catra wasn't aware of time. She wasn't sure how many times she'd been in and out of consciousness. The only thing that she was aware of was pain.

The shackles mercilessly burned her hands. That at least was taking away the sting from all of the other wounds coating her body. But the worst of it was in her head. It felt as if she were wearing a cooking pot as a hat that had sharp razors digging into her scalp. She felt a consistent pressure of both liquid being pumped in and out of her brain simultaneously. Each time it was like a shot of fire was scorching her nerves over and over again.

She heard a door creak open from somewhere in the corner of the dark room. She tensed as footsteps approached, but quickly regretted it as a new wave of pain coursed through her body. "Well, well, well, how the mighty have fallen." A rusty voice croaked as Prime came into eyesight. He grabbed her face and brought it up to his. "I've been wanting to test my new brainwashing method for quite some time, but it only works with a being with independent thought. I was going to test it on Queen Glimmer, but I suppose you will do." He moved away, taking in the sight of her. "What do you say? Should we see if cats really do have nine lives?"

“Nnnghhhhahh,” she cried out in vain.

Prime grabbed a remote from a table to the side of the room, before turning back to her. “Now tell me, who do you serve?”

“I serve no one!” Catra spat on him. She jolted as a shock of electricity cascaded through her metal helmet. She howled in an intense amount of an agony unlike anything she had ever felt before. Her skin felt like it was going to melt off at the unholy sensation.

Prime clicked his tongue. “Wrong answer. You are but a humble servant of Horde Prime.”

Even when the sparks stopped, Catra could still feel its remnants in her head. It hurt so bad, that she could hardly think straight.

“For every wrong answer, you will be reprimanded.” Prime hummed in satisfaction, tapping a finger against his machine. He smiled as his prisoner flinched. “Within time, you will start to get them right consistently. Now, who do you serve?”

Catra steeled herself. She would never give in to this monster. “I told you. I. Don’t. Serve. AnyAYAHHh!!!” She was cut off by another shock wave. This one lasted longer, a horrendous amount of time that only stopped when she could hardly

remember how to breathe. Her flesh prickled with ripples of electricity.

Prime scowled. “Incompetent fool,” he hissed, “I am being merciful. Admit your failures sister and you shall be set free. Let us try again. Who is She-ra to you?”

Catra stared blankly at him. “She-ra?” She paused trying to think. “She- I don’t-AHkkk!!!!”

Prime pressed the button, holding it in for not 10 but 20, 30, 40 long seconds. “You took too long child. A true servant of myself would have given me an answer right away.” He growled.

For a long moment Catra stay still, her body falling forwards. Her arms betrayed her as they held fast to the wall.

Prime lifted her face once more. Blood had started to trickle down from some unseen wound. “It appears as if your body won’t last much longer. I’d suggest you start cooperating.” He pushed her back hard.

Catra let out a low moan as her chin hit her chest. She no longer had the strength to support herself. Prime grabbed a cup thoughtlessly and held it to his lips. He took a long sip before throwing the remaining liquid into the girls face.

As shriek erupted in the room as the water made the electrocution all the worse. She threw herself forward, hardly feeling the chains, even as they dug out pieces of flesh. She had to get out! That was the only thing she cared about. She screamed until her voice grew hoarse and then, only when the helmet fused with her skull, did she go silent. She slumped forward, crippled and broken, her eyes staying trained on the ground.

Still, Prime kept going. His finger hovered over the button, ready to hit it at a moments notice. “What is your name, little sister?”

The poor girl didn’t move, didn’t speak. She was no longer capable of basic human functions.

Prime stormed over to her, ripping the helmet off her head. The metal pulled most of her hair with it, along with chunks of deep red. He scowled at the sight. It was truly disappointing. He had really been looking forward to showing She-ra his latest masterpiece.

* * *

Catra felt her stomach growl as she eyed the ration bars on the table. It had been a hard day of training and her body was begging her to eat, but she just couldn’t bring herself to. She would just sneak back to the room when no one was looking.

Unfortunately for her, it didn’t look like that was going to happen any time soon. “What’s up?” Adora nudged her with her

shoulder. “Saving room for desert? I hear their serving *punch*!” She through a fist into the air.

Catra couldn’t help but chuckle, despite herself. “That was lame, even for you.”

“What, you didn’t get the *punch*line?” The blonde raised her eyebrows to exaggerate the use of her pun.

Catra rolled her eyes and turned back to the table. “I’m just not hungry today. I think I might be coming down with something.” She lied, swirling the water around in her plastic cup.

Adora held a hand to her friend’s forehead. “Hmm, you don’t feel too warm. Maybe you should go back and lay down for a bit though?”

Catra nodded a little too eagerly. “Yeah, I think I might.” She got up and walked out of the cafeteria. “I’ll see you later.”

* *
*

“Catra?” Adora’s voice called out from the darkness. “You up here?”

"Yeah," she simply stated, "I'm up on the platform."

She briefly heard footsteps as the blonde shuffled on up the ladder. "I checked the room, and you weren't there." She said as she sat down beside her.

"I just needed to get some air."

Adora nodded. "Gotcha, gotcha." After a few unbearable minutes of silence, a string of jumbled words came rushing out of her mouth. "You've been acting weird around me lately? Did I do something to upset you?"

Catra was taken aback by this statement. "Of course not. Don't be stupid."

"Yeah, right. Well, its just, ever since we um, you know, when we played spin the bottle a few months ago, you've been kind of s*tandoffish?"*

Catra nodded. It checked out. It was soon after spin the bottle that all of her shit with Shadow Weaver went down. "Look, I've just been dealing with some stuff. It has nothing to do with you."

Adora stared straight ahead at the starless sky. "I was kind of worried that it was because we, well, kissed." She weakly admitted.

"No. Of course not. Its not like we haven't before."

After another awkward minute, Adora got to her feet. "Right," she clapped her hands together, "well now that that's squared away." She turned to leave, but stopped, leaving her back towards the Magicat. "Umm, Catra?"

"Yeah?"

"I- uh, I've been wondering. I- you kissed me."

"No shit Adora. It was spin the fucking bottle."

"Yeaaahhhhh," the girl drawled out. "But you only kissed me. Why?"

Catra grumbled as she got to her feet. "What the fuck does it matter? You didn't kiss anyone else either."

Ador finally turned around to face her. Their faces were mere inches from one another. "I guess I was just- I was wondering-"

But before she could even finish her sentence, Catra had her lips on hers. Adora hummed in surprise at the sudden contact but didn't pull away. She brought her hands up so one was holding her friend's body in place, while the other mussed with her hair.

Catra dragged her tongue across the bottom of the blonde's lip, silently demanding entrance. Her hands pushed Adora back, their bodies clumsily stumbling into the brick wall.

Adora pushed away ever so slightly, trying to speak between the smothering kisses. "Ca- Catra, wait. Mmmhm. Is- do you… want this?"

Catra backed off and looked into her ocean blue eyes. Of course she wanted this. Each kiss from this sweet, kind girl, took her farther and farther from being Shadow Weaver's "little slut." As their bodies melted against each other, each sin was wiped away, forgotten. While she had Adora in her arms, nothing else mattered. Damn the whole world, for all she cared.

She nodded, rushing back to those pretty lips. Their noses collided and the blonde recoiled. "C- Catra, slow down."

Catra suddenly felt very awkward. She backed away slowly, releasing her grip on the girl. "I thought you wanted this."

Adora reached out a hand, but Catra jumped away. “I do, but I don’t think this is what you want. We’re barely adults yet. We have time to figure out what we are.”

“If you didn’t want me, then **why**? Why would you do that Adora? Why would you lead me on?” She hissed, the words coming out of her mouth, menacing.

“I didn’t mean to lead you on, its just –“

“You know what, its fine.” Catra turned on her heel and stormed away. “Just forget anything ever happened.”

* *
*

When she opened her eyes, she knew who she was. She had a purpose. There was a reason she was in this universe. She was safe here. Here, where she could bask in the glory of the almighty universe.

“Looks like cats really do have nine lives,” her master grinned, “I wonder how many you have left Ms. Catra.”

She stared up at him in awe. “It is my pleasure to serve you Master. Glory be to Horde Prime, the almighty one, ruler of the known universe, conqueror of Etheria.”

Saving Catra Applesauce MeowMeow

Chapter Notes

GASP Is it me again so soon with another chapter? Indeed it is! As usual be cautious a read with care. TW for graphic depictions of violence and torture, and suicidal ideation.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Glory be to Horde Prime, ruler of the known universe, conqueror of Etheria, almighty lord of our world-"

"Cast out the shadows. Cast out the shadows. CAST OUT THE SHADOWS-"

"All must suffer to become pure."

"Cast out the shadows!"

The girl took a deep breath in and let it back out. Everything was so loud. The hive mind was always active, always yelling. She found herself repeating the words in her head unconsciously. It was all she heard all day, every day.

"Submit yourself for examination." Prime ordered from his throne.

The girl knelt before him, revealing her chip. It burned against her skin, but she could barely feel it. She couldn't feel much of anything. After all she was merely a clone, a being with no personality or name or feelings.

She could partially remember a life where she was a sentient being. It had been heart wrenching. The natural world was heart breaking and cruel. She had been hurt time and time again by both those around her and herself. But Prime had relieved her of that misery. He'd taken it from her and now carried the burden himself. It was all thanks to him that she was here right now. He gave her a final chance at life. He gave her a purpose.

"Glory be to Horde Prime." She quoted mindlessly.

The clones around her started to chant along. **"Glory be to Horde Prime. Glory be to our lord Prime, conqueror of the world, healer of disease."**

Prime blinked, each of his four eyes shutting at a time. "Very well indeed." He hummed in satisfaction. "Perhaps my best work yet. Now what do you say sister, to whom do you bow down to?"

"I am but a humble servant of Horde Prime. It is an honor to bask in his glorious light." She rose from the ground.

Prime rose from his chair and slapped her in the face. "Did I give you permission to rise, sister?" He growled, shoving a knee into her stomach, sending her reeling onto the ship's floor.

"I apologize, my lord. It is agony to betray you." She choked out, as she moved back into a kneeling position. "I have let you down. I am unworthy to sit beside you, almighty one."

Prime grinned. He dragged a hand roughly through her short, matted hair, his fingers catching on the burned flesh. Blood drew from the wounds, but the girl didn't make a sound. "My dear sister, I am proud that you admit your mistakes. Now how should we deal with the little outburst?"

"Cast out the shadows! Cast out the shadows!" The hive mind sounded.

"Please, my lord, cleanse me of this filth."

"All beings must suffer to become pure! Cast out the shadows!"

"Very well," Prime hummed, helping his newest recruit to her feet, "afterall what kind of leader wound I be if I didn't give my servants what they want?"

He gripped her hand tightly as they walked out of his throne room. The clones that had been it the room followed them, anxious to watch another being become pure.

"Sister, I'm sure you remember when I helped the one you used to call *Hordak*," he spat out the name, "but I assure you that you are much more valuable to me than he. You are more valuable than any of your brothers here. Do you know why that is little sister?"

"No Horde Prime." She bowed her head in submission. The entourage walked through a set of massive glass doors that led into the purification chamber. Most of the room consisted of a pool, that seemed to glow green with the sins of its past users. There was a platform that led from the door to the very middle, where it then would be lowered until its victim would find themselves submerged.

He walked her onto the platform and stroked her choppy hair. "You are valuable because of the one you love."

"I only live to serve you." She bowed her head.

"I know that's not true, not entirely. For, if I didn't have to take such drastic measures," he gestured to her mangled scalp, "I know that you would still only be loyal to She-ra."

Tears formed in her eyes. "I am unworthy of your light. You must save me from the dark of the universe!" She begged, falling to her knees.

"Oh no, little sister. I'm not mad. It's the natural state of Etherians, always so emotional. But we can use this to our advantage. For you will prove your worth to me when you take

She-ra down for me.” He whispered in her ear, so only the two of them could know what was being said.

Take down She-ra? She’d heard that somewhere before. It felt like something she’s wanted to do for a long time. Was it her mission from her past life? Or was it just the knowledge that her master instilled upon her?

Prime raised his hands triumphantly, now shouting to all of his clones. “Rejoice brothers for the day of reckoning will soon be upon us! Watch as our humble sister becomes the purest of all of you! Watch and follow her example!”

Several of the clones tried to push their way onto the platform, all of them wishing to be cleansed along with their sister. Prime simply shook his head and they retreated. “This is not your day brothers! This day is a celebration for me and our little sister, who is about to see the true power I have over the universe. Follow her example and you too shall be made pure!”

“Cast out the shadows! Cast out the shadows!” The clones cheered from the audience.

Horde Prime retreated to join his brethren from the side of the room, leaving the girl alone on the platform. “What say you little sister? Are you ready to see my light?”

“All beings must suffer to become pure.” She spoke proudly before she was plunged into the pool of acid. As her screams finally died away, a new being emerged, the loyal servant of her gracious lord.

***

Little Sister walked through the hall on her way to her throne room. The hive mind had summoned her. She didn't know why. She didn't care.

All she knew was that when she heard her master mumble "Come here child," she was to go to him no questions asked.

Sister paused when she entered the room. A blonde was there, staring right at her. She knew that blonde. Adora. That was the name she went by. She hadn't seen her in a very long time. Maybe two-three hundred years? She wasn't sure how time moved here, only that more life ebbed and flowed in her short time here than she had ever witnessed on Etheria.

She drew her hood back and smiled. She was at peace now and was pleased to see someone she knew. Perhaps Adora could join her, basking under the light of her savior?

"Hello Adora." She spoke softly.

"What did you do to her!?" The girl freaked out, eyes growing wide.

That was a weird response, was it not? Nevertheless, Sister lay herself down before the almighty ruler.

“I have made her anew. I saw her mind, so ensnared in rage, and grief, and pain, and I brought her to the light.” Prime helped the girl to her feet. Little sister gazed up at him in adoration. He had truly saved her. “Isn’t that right, Little Sister?”

“Catra!” Adora yelled. “You have to fight it!”

‘Fight it? Fight what?’ Little Sister wondered. “My place is with Horde Prime, Adora. I don’t want to leave.”

Prime was mercy, Prime was refuge. He took all the grief and pain and torment from the world and relieved her of it. She didn’t need to feel anything, not when her savior could feel it for her. Why would anyone want to give that up?

“Tell her what I’ve done for you.” Prime urged.

Little Sister walked over to Adora, grinning. “Prime has given me peace. Something you could never do.” She placed a hand on one of Adora’s rosy cheeks. She faintly remembered that blush from all those years ago. She had loved it back then, the warmth it had brought. Adora hated to admit that she blushed, so she had pretended not to ever see it. But she had thought it was the cutest thing.

She shook her, head trying to rid herself of her own thoughts. She no longer needed to remember; Horde Prime could do that for her. Afterall, she was merely a humble servant to his majesty.

"You broke my heart, but he has made it whole again. Don't you see? This is for the best. I'm happy here. You could be happy too."

Yes. She was truly at peace now, but if Adora came with her, she would finally be home. She felt nothing as a tear rolled from the blonde's bright blue eyes. The eyes that she remembered looking longingly into for so long, just wanting to spend the rest of her life looking into their depths. And now all her dreams could come true. Adora just needed to say yes, and she would be set free. Prime was always merciful towards those that admitted their faults.

"Let her go!" She demanded instead.

Little Sister's face fell. Did she not want to have a peaceful existence alongside her? Was she still angry about whatever had happened on Etheria? Little sister no longer felt rage, the only thing inside her was peace. Adora could have that too if she wanted. They could leave everything in the past while they worshipped their lord together.

"Shall we make a deal Adora?" Prime placed a hand on Little Sister's shoulder. Her mind went blank as the hive mind took back over. Prime was speaking now. It was time to be silent. "I will give

her to you, if you want her. But first, you must do something for me. You will give me She-ra."

"Never!" Adora growled, showing off that defiance that had always been a part of her. Catra used to admire it, but now she's seen the error of her ways. One should never bite the hand that fed them.

"Very well," Prime snapped his fingers and Adora fell to the floor in agony. Her earpiece sent shocks through her body that reminded Little sister of the bad thing. She'd pushed it from her mind, wishing to forget the torture. But hints of the memory weaved its way to the front of her mind, sending a shudder of fear through her spine. "You miscalculated. I see all, I know all! You thought yourself worthy to challenge me, but you are nothing but a false hero, the last of the First Ones to fall at my hands. You have led your friends to destruction." He tightened his grip on Little Sister's neck.

As she grimaced in pain, she felt something give way. It was only for a moment, but in that little time she saw the world as it really was. Horde Prime hadn't saved her, he'd tortured her. He wiped her mind. She was nothing but a slave to him. She was valuable only as long as he needed to catch Adora.

As suddenly as her clarity came it had gone. She had been stupid to question her master. She was unclean. She needed to prove her worth. She needed to follow his example.

"Go on, fulfil your purpose," he chided, "bring out She-ra and strike me down." He patted his little sister's marred head. "Ah, but

you two have a lot of catching up to do. I will leave you to it. Let me know when you are ready to make a deal."

As soon as he left the room, Little Sister unsheathed her claws and lunged at the blonde. It was what Prime wanted. She would make him proud. She managed to strike a few blows before Adora caught her and held her firmly by the wrist.

"Catra, listen to me. I know you're still in there. I'm not leaving without you. It's gonna be okay."

Little Sister cringed at that name. It was nothing but another gateway to her past life. She bent her hand back until she could hear the bones snap. She smiled up at her former friend in pity before she dragged the claws on her broken hand across the girl's pretty face. She twisted around so she could keep her in a chokehold.

"Everything is already okay. We are with Prime now!" She assured the girl. She just wished that she would rejoice alongside her. "There is no need for you to suffer Adora. Come into the light with me."

Adora shrieked, making the girl loosen her grip. While she had her distracted, she threw her backwards. Little sister hit hard against the wall, feeling her chip spark.

Catra laughed. Adora was being so foolish! If she'd just go with her everything would be perfect.

"Snap out of it Catra!" Adora begged. "I don't wanna hurt you."

This made her laugh even harder. Who was Adora to talk? "But you have already hurt me. Prime has set me free of that pain. The pain that you caused. He will set us all free, forever." It truly was an honor to bask in his merciful light. If only everyone could see it like that. But alas, the chips would surely help with that. "A world of peace, without end."

She missed when she lunged at Adora, causing her to land near the edge of the platform. Something crooked formed in her face at the sight. The long fall down reminded her of death. If she jumped, everything would be over. She had jumped before. She could do it again.

Adora saw that look in her face and ran over to catch her. "Catra! No!" She grabbed onto her arm at the last second, bringing her to safety. She held her body so close against her own, that Little Sister could hardly breathe.

Catra shrugged it off. Oh well. Prime would have been disappointed if she killed herself. She dug her nails into Adora's back and hummed, now in Prime's voice. "Oh, Adora. How long will you drag this out?" Her claws scraped long and hard down her friend's body. "You will destroy the ones you live in the process." She kneed the girl and the gut, the grabbed her and dangled her over the edge. She smiled at Adora's little grunt of pain.

“She was afraid in the end,” Horde Prime spoke from his little sister’s body, “and she suffered. You should have seen her face when I electrocuted her for the last time. You should have seen how her scalp had fused with the hot metal, the blood that had literally boiled. You should thank me that I used my resources to keep her from losing her last life. After all, without me she would have never survived with a melted, deformed skull, not to mention the sores on her body from when she tried to pull away from the hot metal chains.” He chuckled. “Perhaps I will make her my new vessel, though she would not last me very long. What do you think Adora?”

Adora shoved her into the wall. Catra chuckled as pain ignited in her head. Everything was blurry as she tried to come to terms with the agony that resided in her brain. She was relieved when the chip took control once more and she was released from the awful jaws of torture.

“I am not giving up on you Catra!”

“Then you’re a fool.” She stated simply. “You cannot stop Horde Prime. He will reign triumphant over all the universe. It is destiny.”

Prime sent a burst of flames through the room. Catra screamed in pain, but not from the fire. The chip was failing, sending sparks through her entire body. Adora pushed her out of the fire’s reach, but it was not enough to escape the horrors of her own mind.

Catra saw Adora when she opened her eyes. Not the Adora that had left her for She-ra, not Prime's twisted image of Adora, just Adora. Adora who would hold her when she cried, Adora who she had shared her first kiss with, Adora who knew her better than anyone in the entire universe. This was her Adora, the one that she loved. For a moment she was overjoyed. And then realization dawned on her. It wasn't safe for her to be here. "Adora, you should have stayed away. Why did you come back? We both know I don't matter."

"You matter to me," the blonde spoke softly as she caressed her cheek.

A tear rolled from her cheek. Did Adora really care about her, even after all this time? Catra felt Prime trying to take back control. She fought it as much as she could, not wanting to lose this moment. But in the end, she was no match for him. He was in her head. He forced her to walk to the ledge. Little sister grabbed her neck as the chip shocked her.

"Come on Catra!" She distantly heard Adora call. "You've never listened to anyone in your life, are you really going to start now?"

Catra gave Adora a last warm smile. She knew what was coming. She'd gone through it eight times before. But this time, when Prime killed her, when she killed herself, whatever was going to happen, she wouldn't come back. This was her last life, and she was looking at her Adora for the last time. "You're such an idiot."

"Yeah, I know!" Adora smiled, unaware of what was about to go down. That was okay. She couldn't save her anyway. 'I'm going to take you home."

“Promise?” Catra whispered, even though she knew it was one that could never be fulfilled.

“I promise!” Adora agreed.

“Adora- “ She reached out her hand, for once letting herself hope that everything would be okay. Perhaps she would win this and bring her home. Perhaps everything would be alright, just this time. Then, Prime took control for the last time. “Disappointing. Some creatures are destined only for destruction.” He said through her mouth before leaving her head, making sure Catra was fully aware as she died. He sent a shock of electricity through her implant and Catra fell all the way to the ground.

Her screams seemed to go on for long minutes, her impending doom being drawn out longer than it needed to be. She shut her eyes tightly as she saw to floor getting closer and closer. They said cats always land on their feet, but not even she could survive a fall from that height.

Her already damaged head cracked open upon impact, her wrist and leg shattered. And the worst part was that she didn’t die instantly. She was conscious through the most intense pain she had ever felt.

In her short life Catra had managed to kill herself by jumping off of buildings, being eaten by a giant robot spider, died twice from the effects of a cursed portal that she had set off, been killed by

Adora's new best friend, been killed by Hordak, and died from severe torture. And now it looked like she was ending how it all began. She was going to plummet to her demise. Only this time Catra didn't want to die. This time she wanted to go with Adora, to go home. And this time she had no choice whether she lived or died.

She choked and felt a warm liquid dripping from her mouth. The bitter taste of blood seized her senses. Her sight failed her and at last she was left alone with nothing but her final thoughts and memories.

When she thought back on her life, she didn't see her suffering. She saw her Adora holding her after each beating, Adora sharing her bed with her, because Catra hated to sleep alone, she remembered how Adora had begged her to run away with her. Because Adora loved her.

And as Catra closed her eyes for the last time, she knew that was all she ever needed. To love and to be loved by her Adora.

Chapter End Notes

> So this is the last life that Catra has to lose, but I want to assure you this story is not yet over. And as a warning the next chapter will depict a suicide attempt which may be hard for some readers. Just be safe and let me know what you think below. As always, I love you guys!

Second Chances

Chapter Summary

TW: Gore, Self-Harm, Attempted Suicide, Depression

Chapter Notes

Okay. So, I know it's been a long time. Too long really. But this chapter was really hard to right. As someone who has struggled with thoughts of worthlessness, I want each and every one of you to know that it's not true. You are perfect just the way you are. And on that note, as usual, please only read this if the subject matter doesn't bother you. Be safe guys!!!

Catra slid down against the cold metal door, tears streaming down her face. Her crying had long since stopped and her grief was taken over by an utter emptiness. It was all over. Adora was gone. She had left her, and no one was here to keep her safe from her own mind.

If someone had told her a month ago that her best friend would abandon her, both she and the blonde would have scoffed at them. There was no way anything could separate the two of them, right? It had been that way since they were kids, when Adora had given her a place in the Horde, a home, she'd even go as far to say that she'd given her a family.

Because no matter how bad things got, they could always cling to each other. It didn't matter what the other kids said, it didn't even matter what Shadow Weaver did.

But now Adora was gone. No one cared about Catra anymore, not a single one of them.

She supposed now that no one was there to protect her, her daily beatings would get worse. It wouldn't only be her caretaker that took advantage of the poor girl, but every other kid in the Fright Zone that had been held at bay from pure fear of the blonde.

Adora had always been the most promising cadet. And so when she was mad about something, she almost always got her way. Even when it came to Catra. So long as she knew what was happening, she would try to stop it.

Catra hadn't been able to tell her about Shadow Weaver raping her. It was something that she'd felt too much shame for. That was the only reason she had been helpless. That and she was just plain stubborn and wouldn't ask for help if it killed her. But now she didn't even have the choice to ask for protection.

Catra stood on wobbly legs, her feet barely supporting her. She made her way over to one of the other kid's bedsides. She stared at a framed photograph; the cadet had snuck in with them. Two figures smiled up at her, almost mocking her.

Taking a quick glance over her shoulder first, she slowly took apart the frame. The glass was cool under her fingers as she slid it out from the wood background. She left the latter along with the photo on the cadet's dresser for him to find later. It wasn't that she was after.

Holding the glass carefully in her hands, she slowly walked into the bathroom. There were so many memories in here, nearly all of them bad. This room had been literally stained with her blood and tears. But after tonight, it never would be again. Because after tonight, no one would ever hurt her again.

She turned the tap on with her free hand and set the glass on the floor with the other. She took a deep breath and let it out. She wasn't sure what was going to happen when she crushed the glass with her bare foot. Would it protrude inside, drawing blood and leaving a nasty scar?

She snorted and mentally rolled her eyes at her own stupidity. What did it matter? She would be dead soon anyway.

With slow and cautious movements, she slammed her heel down on the glass. It shattered instantly, but she felt no pain. Bending over, she picked up the largest piece she could find before ultimately climbing into the tub.

In and out, she breathed. Her mind was riddled with so much pain, that the hot water hardly registered as she sunk into its depths. She briefly wondered what Adora was doing right then. Was she thinking about her at all? Did she even care?

No*, she decided solemnly,* if Adora had cared at all, then Catra wouldn't be here right now.

And maybe it wasn't her fault. Catra was a bitch. She lowered the glass to her forearm, making the first gash.

She was stupid.

She was selfish.

She was a slut.

She was nothing.

With each cruel thought, she cut herself deeper and deeper. Thick, sticky liquid bubbled up like a geyser, turning the water in the tub a murky red.

She was a waste.

Nothing but a mistake.

Her parent's had been right to leave her behind. Shadow Weaver had been right to hate her.

Catra's breath hitched in her throat as her slicing finally seized. It was done. Her body was marked up with old scars and new. Blood continuously pooled from her gaping wounds, making her fainter by the second.

Her eyes drooped and her breath grew shakier and shakier.

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The air was tight in Catra's chest as she gasped for air. Her memories came flashing back to her as she came to. *Adora- no, no, no! Prime was going to kill her. She had to keep her away. She had to-*

She tried to push herself up, only to have her head explode in agony. The room seemed to spin, and she could hardly make anything out between all of the flying colors. A thick cry built up in her throat, but she couldn't even tell if it escaped or not.

What she was aware of was the hot rise of vomit rising in her body. A metallic taste accompanied by whatever she had eaten last- whenever that had been, she couldn't remember- exited her already parched mouth. She heaved as her weak body convulsed with each roll of her stomach.

She had to get up. She had to stop Prime. She had to save Adora.

But she simply didn't have the strength to. Weakly, she rolled back over on her side, her face smearing with the contents of her body. Sleep was merciful enough to take her quickly and easily.

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It was dawn when Catra came to. She was so groggy and lightheaded that she could hardly remember anything. The only thing she had to remember of last night were the thick wounds that still leaked red.

The next thing she noticed was the sound of running water. Someone must have forgot to turn off the tap after their bath. She should probably turn it off.

It was only when she failed to lift her body that she realized the extent of her actions. Catra had tried to take her own life. She sliced herself until she couldn't move. And she failed. How, she had no clue. How could anyone survive injuries like this? It was impossible.

And yet, here she was. Alive and alone, just like before. Only now, she was more broken than ever.

She finally managed to sit up just enough to turn off the tap and drag herself out of the tub. Her body fell to the floor like a broken doll. Broken glass dug into her flesh as she landed on the shattered frame. The sting didn't bother her though. It was nothing compared to the other gaping wounds she bared.

Slowly, she finally managed to get up and crawl to her bed. Catra was tired. She was tired of the constant pain she inflicted upon herself. Perhaps she should just stop. Perhaps she should try to move past this all. If she couldn't die, then she could at least find something to live for. She lay there, curled into a ball, as darkness took over her world once more.

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The sound of crying woke her from her restless sleep. Her body still thrummed with pain, but she at least had a grasp on reality. She was able to remember the events of yesterday- or at least the parts she was conscious for.

Adora had come for her. Prime had killed her. But somehow- somehow Adora had saved her. Somehow, she brought her back to life.

"You need to wake up," a voice whispered from the darkness, "I already lost you once. I won't lose you again. I- I won't. I can't."

Adora. That was Adora, Catra realized. She sighed in relief. Her friend was safe.

"I fucked up Catra. I left you when I knew you needed me. I should have waited for you. We always planned to run away together. But I just left you there. And- and it's all my fault that this happened to you.

"You always acted so strong. I thought you were okay. And I shouldn't have. Because you were- you *are* my best friend. I should have seen that you were suffering. But I was just too focused on some great destiny.

"But Catra, you are my destiny. I would be nothing without you. Everyone used to say that I saved you. And maybe I did in some ways. But Catra. Catra, you were the one that saved me.

"You taught me how to love Catra. You taught me how to live. You gave me the best life possible. And- I was never there for you. I'm so, so sorry. I'm sorry."

The words cut deep into Catra's already broken heart. They were echoes of what she used to pray to hear. Only now they were true. And they came from the person who she needed to hear them from the most.

As the blonde cried, Catra reached out a tired hand and placed it on top of her friend's.

Friend. That was such a funny word. It wasn't quite right to sum up everything the girls had been through. Sure, they had been friends when they were little. Then they became something much more powerful. And even after they fought tooth and claw, that power still seemed to be there. It seemed to hold them together, never letting them drift too far apart.

"'Dora," she whispered, "you did save me. So many times."

It was hard to open her crusted-over eyelids, but when she managed to see Adora's smile, it was all worth it. She made sure to etch every feature into her mind to remember, before letting her world commence into a dark void.

"Catra!?" Adora's tired gasp filled the room. She shifted as though she wasn't sure what to do with her body.

Catra chuckled. Yep, that was her Adora alright. Still as jittery as ever. "Oh, just get over here already."

That was all Adora needed to practically lunge herself at the girl. She was mindful of the injuries that covered her body as she enveloped her in the tightest hug that she dared, lest she hurt the girl. "I thought I lost you."

“No. You can’t get rid of me that easily.” Catra weakly grinned, cradling the blonde next to her body. She let out a weak sigh as she let herself fall into a daze. Everything was okay now, at least for the moment. No one could hurt her now that she was back where she should be, by Adora’s side.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

> So, this is it. The final chapter. It's been a long ride but I hope you've all enjoyed it. I have loved writing it so much, even if my updates were inconsistent. And I hope you all stick around for my future works, cause I have a lot more ideas.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had lived a full life. There had been as many joys as there had been sorrows. But now, facing death for the final time, she had only one question to ask: 'Was love worth it?'

There are only three types of people in the world, she decided.

There were the optimists, who never failed to see life through rose-tinted glasses. They would say 'yes' no matter the case. They cared not for the sadness the world may bring upon them, so long as they had their so-called soulmate besides them.

Then there were the pessimists. They would instantly answer 'no.' They were smart in Catra's mind. They knew too well the price of love. You would end up getting hurt, so many times. They would think they were better off without enduring any of that.

And while that may all seem black and white, a definitive answer to one of the world's oldest questions, there was

one more group. The group that Catra found herself in. These were the people who knew the price of love and still chose to endure it. They faced more hardships than anyone could have known. But ultimately, they were proven to be the strongest of them all. They got hurt yes, but they were able to heal and move on. They were able to love again and again. And perhaps they were stupid for it. Perhaps they didn't even realize what they were doing. Maybe they still couldn't answer that question. But that was okay. You don't always need to know the answer. Its what's in your soul that matters.

The strongest of swords have to endure the most trauma. They are placed in extreme temperatures before they've completed their purpose. This helps make them who they are supposed to become. And ultimately, its what makes the testing of a hero.

Catra scoffed at herself. She had gone soft in her old age. Adora had made her soft.

As she walked through the castle of Brightmoon she thought back at all the memories she had here. About a year after Lord Prime's defeat she had exchanged vows with her Dora. While they weren't perfect they were the words Catra needed to hear. "You are and will always be loved."

They had just been kids then. They didn't know what the future held. Hell- they hardly even knew what a family was supposed to look like. But they managed to learn for themselves. And then Finn came along with his endless happiness and laughter.

Now Catra wouldn’t say he was the glue that held their little family together. Her and Adora could do that on their own. But he was to them what a lightbulb is to a house. He expanded their views on life and made everything easier to see. They had loved him with unending fervor.

Now, looking back, she could still hear his little footsteps running around the throne room, while Sparkles would chase him out, pretending to be mad. She never truly was though. He was like a child to both her and Bow, who weren’t able to have their own.

In the next room over, she saw Adora teaching Fynn how to dance on the eve of his first Princess Prom. Even at the age of 17 he was still as notoriously bad at dancing as his mother. But the two of them found their own unique rhythm that made them look like naturals.

That had been a particularly hard day, if she remembered correct. A heinous criminal had been at large, and as one of Brightmoon’s knights it had been her duty to stop his murderous path. Several blows to the head and one epic fight later she sauntered into the castle. Adora had stopped mid-dance to rush over to her, upon seeing the cuts on her wife’s head.

She had brushed it off as clumsiness, if only for her Finny’s benefit. Her wife could always see past her lies. And later that night, when it was just the two of them in their cozy bedroom, she made sure Catra knew she was loved.

She stopped in the Banquet Hall as visions of her boys wedding swam around her. His bride Luna had been the daughter she'd never had. And when only three months later she died from a disease no one knew she'd been fighting; it had physically broken her. Especially knowing that she was with child. And while Finny had never remarried he made a beautiful family of his own.

Sixteen years of blood, sweat, and tears proved his dedication to establishing the first orphanage of what used to be the Fright Zone. Children would never see that place as their own personal hell again. Instead, it would become a beacon of hope for anyone in need of love. Catra couldn't be prouder of her baby boy.

And as for her friends, they had also grown into their own rolls in their new lives on Etheria. Shortly after the defeat of Lord Prime, Scorpia made her way back to the Crimson Waste where she and Perfuma ruled with grace and mercy. The two of them were absolutely perfect for each other. When Scorpia took things too far, Perfuma was always there to reel her back in. And when Perfuma lost her will, Scorpia could bring out her strong side.

Entrapta was content in staying amongst her robots, but she often came to Bright Moon whenever the loneliness became too much.

As for Mermista, she ruled her kingdom with all the wisdom of the seas. And while she was perfectly capable of doing

that on her own, Catra could see her joy whenever her boyfriend, Sea Hawk, returned home from one of his many adventures.

And then there was Queen Glimmer and Prince Bow, who had made room in their castle and hearts for five little orphans they had met at Finn's orphanage. The future of Bright Moon was in good hands.

Catra took a shaky breath as she finally reached the end of the hall, where her and Adora's room was. She didn't want to go in. She wanted to turn and run the other way. But she couldn't do that, not anymore. She couldn't let her girl do this alone. So with a trembling hand she shoved the door open and made her way to their bed.

Adora's hand was clammy in hers. She rubbed a hand along her face, holding her close. "Hey Adora." Her voice was a mere whisper.

At first Catra thought she had imagined the glint of blue coming from her wife's eyes, but a weak voice told her otherwise. "Kitty? Where have you been?"

A sob caught in her throat. "I'm sorry Dora. I should have been here sooner."

Adora hummed. "Catra… Catra Applesauce MeowMeow. I need to tell you something."

A tear rolled down Catra’s face, but she didn’t dare move her hand to wipe it away. “What’s that, princess?”

“I think… I think we’re gonna be okay. In the Fright Zone, I mean. I can be a Force Captain. And then you can be my general.”

Catra nodded slowly. It was better this way; Adora only remembering the good memories. She didn’t need her last moments to be in agony of the past trauma. So she slowly kissed her wife’s forehead and whispered. “That sounds perfect princess.”

Chapter End Notes

I love you guys so much! And yes. I'm sorry I killed her...

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!